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'PREMATURE PETITION'

Vande Mataram advisory not a 'threat to conform': SC

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AGAINST THE TREND

Drying of Cauvery to persist until 2050: study

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NARROW DEFINITIONS

The Transgender Bill, a flawed fix

The Bill deepens conflation of gender identities and ignores core crises

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INDIAN OPEN GOLF

Bhatia and Molinari head a strong field

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Iran dismisses U.S. bid to end conflict, sets its own terms

Halting aggression, reparations, and 'sovereignty' over Strait of Hormuz part of Tehran's terms; U.S. offers sanctions relief for reopening the Strait

Stanly Johny

Iran on Wednesday dismissed a U.S. proposal to end the war and set out its own terms for peace, even as it continued trading fire with Israel.

The U.S. proposal offered a ceasefire and sanctions relief in return for the Islamic Republic abandoning its nuclear programme and reopening the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran, according to state-run Press TV, has laid down five conditions to end the war, which the U.S. and Israel launched on February 28 with the assassination of Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and several other leaders. Tehran is seeking: "a complete halt to aggression and assassinations"; "concrete mechanisms" to prevent future attacks; payment of war damages and reparations; an end to fighting on "all fronts"; and recognition of its "exercise of sovereignty" over the Strait of Hormuz, which it calls its "natural and legal right".

"Iran will end the war



On alert: Security forces and first responders at a site struck by a projectile on the outskirts of Tel Aviv in Israel during the war. AFP

when it decides to do so and when its own conditions are met," a senior security official said, according to Press TV. The official, who is not named in the report, said Washington has put forward proposals through various diplomatic channels that are "excessive" and "disconnected from reality" on the battlefield.

U.S. President Donald Trump, who had backed off from his threat to attack Iran's power infrastructure claiming that Washington and Tehran were in talks, said on Tuesday that Iran

had given him "a very big present worth a tremendous amount of money", adding that "we are dealing with the right people". "I think we're going to end [the war]," Mr. Trump said without elaborating on the "present".

Iran's Khatam al-Anbiya Central Headquarters on Wednesday dismissed reports about talks, adding that the U.S. is calling its "defeat" an agreement.

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RELATED REPORTS ON
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Centre defends stand as Opposition raises 'Pak. role' in West Asia

Sobhana K. Nair
Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

Parrying the questions raised by the Opposition regarding the reported central role played by Pakistan in mediating between the U.S. and Iran, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Wednesday termed the neighbouring country a "dalal" and said that it had been playing this role since 1981.

He was addressing an all-party meeting chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on the recent developments in West Asia and their impact on India. Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Puri also assured the gathering that India continued to maintain a strategic petroleum reserve of 74 days. While the country was not facing any imminent energy crisis, he noted that the supply cycle for Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) had extended from 20 days to 45 days. This, he said, should stabilise soon.

Responding to criticism over India's "silence", Mr. Jaishankar asserted that with nearly one crore Indians living in West Asian countries, it was crucial for India's strategic and economic interests to maintain a balanced position.



S. Jaishankar

India, he said, remained in a unique position, able to communicate with all sides.

Citing Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent talks with Iranian authorities, he said two Indian ships had been allowed to sail through the Strait of Hormuz, while 18 others still in the region would soon set sail for Indian shores. He said that the U.S. continued to be India's biggest trading partner, while Israel was a key technological partner.

The External Affairs Minister also said that the U.S. sanctions on India had a long history and that previous administrations in Washington had deployed them in past. While the Opposition "shamed" the government, he said that India's import of Russian oil never completely stopped.

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NEARBY



Do not impose amendments on transgenders: CM

CHENNAI
Chief Minister M.K. Stalin has said the amendments to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, should not be imposed on the community. » PAGE 6

SDPI, MJK, MPP get one seat each in DMK alliance

CHENNAI
The Social Democratic Party of India, the Manithaneya Jananayaga Katchi, and the Mukkulathor Puli Padai have been allocated one seat each in the DMK-led alliance for the coming polls. » PAGE 6

CMRL begins tunnelling from Thiruvannmiyur

CHENNAI
Chennai Metro Rail's tunnelling work from Thiruvannmiyur to Indira Nagar for the ongoing phase-II project has begun and the machine has drilled nearly 100 metres. » PAGE 5

METROPLUS » 4 PAGES

Govt. revamps UDAN scheme with changes in subsidy

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

In a significant policy shift, the Centre has extended the subsidy period for airlines on select Tier-2 and Tier-3 routes from three to five years, after a large share of those routes fell into disuse. The shift comes under the modified UDAN scheme, approved by the Union Cabinet on Wednesday with a total outlay of ₹28,840 crore.

The subsidy will also shift from a levy embedded in airfares to direct funding from the exchequer.

CONTINUED ON
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India raises clean-energy ambition with 60% non-fossil fuel power goal by 2035

Jacob Koshy
NEW DELHI

Updating its climate goals, India has pledged that by 2035, 60% of its installed electric capacity will comprise non-fossil sources. It also aims to reduce by 47% the intensity of emissions per unit of GDP from 2005 level and to increase its carbon sink to 3.5 billion tonnes – 4 billion tonnes.

These targets make up its Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC), which are to be communicated to the United Nations Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC).

"We will easily achieve these goals... [with] the speed with which we are expanding our non-fossil

Green goals

The targets set for 2035 under the Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) are part of India's formal climate pledges under the Paris Agreement



Reduce emissions intensity of GDP by **47%** from 2005 level

Achieve **60%** installed electric power from non-fossil fuel energy resources

Create carbon sink of **3.5 to 4.0 billion tonnes** of CO₂ equivalent through forest and tree cover

As a signatory to the Paris Agreement, India was required to update its NDC by 2025 with actions towards curbing fossil fuel and improving energy efficiency

sources," Union Information Technology Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said at a briefing on Wednesday following a Cabinet meeting.

As a signatory to the Paris Agreement, India was

required to issue an updated NDC in 2025, which spells out its voluntary actions towards transitioning away from fossil fuel and improving energy-efficiency measures.

At the 30th edition of the Conference of Parties in Belem, Brazil, in November last year, Environment Minister Bhupendra Yadav said that India would announce the NDC by the "year-end".

India's current NDC, officially conveyed to the United Nations in August 2022, commits to the following by 2030: having 50% of its installed electric power from non-fossil sources; reducing the intensity of emissions per unit of GDP by 44%; and increasing its carbon sink to at least 2.5 billion tonnes to 3 billion tonnes of CO₂ equivalent.

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AIADMK releases its first list of candidates; no major surprises

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

The All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) on Wednesday announced its first list of 23 candidates, which included party general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami.

The Dravidian major, which is to contest in 169 Assembly constituencies, has given up four seats, including Avanashi – represented by former Speaker of the Assembly and the party's prominent face of the Scheduled Castes (SC) P. Dhanapal – to accommodate its allies.

At a media briefing in the presence of leaders of National Democratic Alliance (NDA) constituents,



Edappadi K. Palaniswami

Mr. Palaniswami, who will contest from Edappadi for the fifth successive time, made public the details of 64 constituencies assigned to the AIADMK's allies, including 27 seats for the Bharatiya Janata Party.

The AIADMK re-nominated a total of 16 former Ministers, also members of the outgoing Assembly.

While there were hardly any surprises in the choice of names, the list did not have any women or SC candidates.

Of the 23 candidates, the Mukkulathor community accounted for eight persons, Kongu Vellala Gounders five and Vanniyars four.

Barring three candidates – Virudhunagar (West) district secretary K.T. Rajenthra Bhalaji from Sivakasi; Villupuram district secretary C.Ve. Shanmugam from Mailam, and 'Agri' S.S. Krishnamurthy from Kalasapakkam – 20 were re-nominated from their old constituencies.

CONTINUED ON
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INBRIEF



Police Commissioner holds grievance redressal meet

The Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A. Arun on Wednesday held the public grievance redress camp at the Commissioner's Office. He received 23 petitions from the public, and instructed police officials to take swift action. He directed police officers to promptly receive complaints from the public, conduct quick inquiries, and take necessary action. Deputy Commissioner of Police, Administration, G. Subbulakshmi, was also present at the camp, said a press release.



Unauthorised hoardings in city attract fine of ₹1.25 lakh

The Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC) has removed unauthorised advertisement hoardings in Sholinganallur, Kodambakkam, Adyar, and Teynampet zones, a release said. A total fine of ₹1.25 lakh was imposed, with ₹25,000 levied on each violator. The unauthorised hoardings and banners violated provisions under the Tamil Nadu Urban Local Bodies Rules, 2023. The civic body warned that repeated violations would attract penalties of up to ₹1 lakh, the release further said. The GCC has mandated that all advertisement boards be installed only after obtaining a licence through its online portal, and undergoing scrutiny by a single-window committee. The public can report violations by contacting helpline 1913. The Corporation said details of licensed hoardings were available on its website.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper. thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 26, Thursday), the following articles are available:

- What is at stake at the WTO's MC14? newsth.live/wtoconference
- West Asia war: how finding oil changed the Persian Gulf's ecology newsth.live/oilecology

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

HC allows petition to summon Telecom Secretary as witness in telephone exchange case

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Wednesday allowed a plea by DMK MP Dayanidhi Maran to summon the Union Telecommunication Secretary to depose as a court witness before the trial court here in the illegal telephone exchange case booked for alleged offences committed during his stint as the Union Minister between 2004 and 2007. Justice A.D. Jagadish Chandira wrote: "In the instant case, where the allegations involve the provision and utilisation of telecommunication infrastructure, the interpretation of administrative rules and the functioning of public sector entities during the relevant period; the evidence of individuals who were directly connected with the relevant administrative processes, assumes significance."

He said the testimony of those individuals may shed light on the factual and procedural aspects underlying the allegations and may assist the special court

for MP/MLA cases in Chennai to appreciate the evidence, already on record, in its proper perspective. Therefore, it was essential to summon those individuals and examine them as court witnesses to discern the truth, he added.

"In matters relating to departmental facilities and administrative privileges, the scope and nature of entitlement may vary depending upon the position held and the functional requirements of the office. In such circumstances, the person best placed to clarify the administrative framework governing such entitlement would be the Secretary (Telecom), who functions as the senior-most executive authority," the judge said.

The case against Mr. Maran and many other co-accused had been booked by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI).

According to the prosecution, he had dishonestly procured a large number of telecom facilities at his Boat Club residence as well as home office in Chennai, in connivance with senior

officials of BSNL and permitted those facilities to be used for the business purposes of Sun TV Network Limited.

Alleging that the CBI had not examined many individuals as prosecution witnesses, thereby depriving them of a chance to cross-examine those witnesses, Mr. Maran and Sun TV Network's Chief Technical Officer S. Kannan had approached the High Court with a plea to permit the summoning of those individuals as court witnesses.

Justice Chandira allowed Mr. Kannan's sole petition and permitted the summoning of Rakesh Kumar Somani, who had served as AGM (Vigilance), BSNL, New Delhi. Similarly, the judge allowed five different petitions filed by Mr. Maran and permitted the summoning of individuals named therein as court witnesses.

He, however, dismissed the former Minister's sixth petition for summoning individuals named A. Mahalingam and Mohan Lal Sindhia as court witnesses.

‘Notices have been issued to e-commerce platforms that engage in unfair practices’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Notices have been issued to e-commerce platforms for engaging in unfair practices that violate consumer rights, said Anupam Mishra, Additional Secretary, Union Ministry of Consumer Affairs.

In his virtual address at a seminar on 'Responsible use of AI in consumer products and services' organised by Citizen consumer and civic Action Group (CAG) along with VIT Chennai, Mr. Mishra explained how artificial intelligence-enabled dark patterns were being used to manipulate consumers into making unfair choices.

The Ministry had identified 13 dark patterns used by online platforms, including creating false urgency (such as only two choices being left), basket sneaking (adding items or brochures without consent), and subscription trapping. Moreover, Guidelines for Prevention and Regulation of Dark Pat-

terns, 2023, had been issued and notices sent to e-commerce platforms adopting such unfair practices, he said.

L. Jeganathan, professor, School of Computer Science and Engineering, VIT Chennai, said that AI systems could sometimes produce logically convincing but incorrect conclusion. He pointed to issues such as algorithmic bias that could lead to unfair outcomes due to biased data and data drift that could reduce accuracy over time.

AI's impact

Elaborating on AI's impact on consumers, Geetha Raju, senior policy analyst, Centre for Responsible AI, IIT-Madras, cited global instances of AI-related failures and stressed the significance of identifying risks at the data collection stage. CAG executive director S. Saroja said it was a platform to initiate multidisciplinary dialogue on evolving AI-driven consumer ecosystems and to identify policy gaps.

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Lack of civic amenities irks residents as urbanisation takes toll on constituency

Nearly half of Thiruporur constituency's electorate live along a 30-km stretch of highly urbanised 'vertical villages'; the past decade saw urbanisation leading to a strain on its resources; lack of piped water supply, inadequate schemes for farmers, and poor road infrastructure are some key issues

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Saptarshi Bhattacharjee
CHENNAI

It has a sizeable coastal belt stretching over 30 km, a large expanse of reserved forest areas, a few industrial parks, several well-known higher education institutions, and a substantial stretch of agricultural land spread over two revenue blocks. Yet, nearly half of its electorate reside along a 30-km stretch of highly urbanised 'vertical villages'. The Thiruporur Assembly constituency – situated south of Chennai on the iconic IT Corridor along the Old Mahabalipuram Road (OMR) – in Chengalpattu district, is indeed a study in dichotomy.

The expansion of Chennai's IT Corridor over the past couple of decades has resulted in the mushrooming of large multi-storeyed apartments, extending well into the villages on either side of the road.

Nearly 45% of its 2,89,401 voters live in the 100-odd high-rise residential complexes in Navalur, Padur, Siruseri, Pudupakkam, Mambakkam, Kelambakkam, and other adjoining village panchayat areas. As demand for housing grew, these extended areas gradually came to be dotted with 'sheltered communities', with IT employees from within Chennai city limits moving there for affordability.

"The rental rates have nearly doubled in the past decade," said K. Sivaraman, an advocate whose

Thiruporur

Thiruporur is a constituency with a diverse demographic. It also includes a long coastal belt, reserve forests, an old temple-town, a large expanse of agricultural lands, and several big high-rise apartments housing IT employees

KEY ISSUES

- Some of the high-rise apartments lack basic amenities such as piped water supply and proper road facilities
- Lack of underground sewage network and solid waste management facilities
- With returns from agriculture falling, farmers in several villages have leased out their wells to water supply agencies who supply water to the high-rise apartments through tankers
- Fishermen in Nemmeli and other areas along the coast have been complaining of reduced catch ever since the desalination plants began operations

2021 Assembly election result:

S.S. Balaji of the VCK defeated K. Arumugam of the PMK by a margin of **1,947 votes**

Electors before SIR: Total: 3,12,939

Men : 1,53,425
Women : 1,59,458
Others : 56

Electors after SIR: Total: 2,89,401

Men : 1,40,991
Women : 1,48,359
Others : 51

Number of polling stations 369

Sorry state: The polluted Thangal Lake along Nemmeli Link Road in Thiruporur constituency. R. RAGU

family has been residing in the temple town for generations. The surge in population has resulted in a strain on resources. "These urbanised areas do not have piped water supply. Each family shells out about ₹4,000-₹5,000 a month for maintenance costs, a large part of it going towards procuring tanker water," he added.

In villages, including Ilalur, Thaiyur, and Kolathur, many farmers have leased out their farm wells to private water supply

agencies for extraction since returns from agriculture have been on the wane, he said. "The government hasn't done much to improve the lot of the farmers; most of the government schemes haven't reached them," said Mr. Sivaraman, who is also an AIADMK functionary.

Vertical villages

The village panchayats also lacked the resources to invest in underground sewage treatment facility for the highly urbanised OMR

stretch. The area had plenty of problems related to road infrastructure, street-lighting, and security. In came the Federation of OMR Residents Association (FOMRRA), born about a decade ago much out of necessity to address these day-to-day problems in innovative and sustainable ways, says Harsha Koda, design entrepreneur and co-founder of FOMRRA.

An experiment with collecting rain water in large underground sumps to be used by residents soon

caught on, with about 20 apartment buildings implementing the system. The reliance on tanker supply eased a bit, but was not enough.

With the membership of over a hundred high-rise apartments in Thiruporur constituency, FOMRRA soon became a strong pressure group asking questions of government agencies. "We have about 1.3 lakh voters living in these 'vertical villages' within Thiruporur constituency. This is a cosmopolitan crowd where the conventional 'freebies' or caste equations do not work," Mr. Koda said.

Political party representatives require to balance their manifestos to accommodate the demands of both these worlds, says Prabha Koda, coordinator of FOMRRA.

So, how does it influence the issues in other parts of the constituency? Ms. Koda says that a large number of people residing near the high-rise apartments eke out a living offering services to the residents of these apartments, from tanker water supply to housekeeping, plumbing, and electrical jobs. "The benefits will definitely flow to them as well, because the demands for basic amenities such as water and sanitation are the same," she adds.

In Thiruporur town, traffic snarls are common most days. The Kandaswamy Temple witnesses a surge of devotees, especially on auspicious days, and parking and other infrastructure often get clogged,

says Mr. Sivaraman.

A four-kilometre stretch of road connects Thiruporur to Nemmeli, a fishing hamlet on the East Coast Road. The road is barely motorable as it has been dug up for laying water pipelines. The fishermen in Nemmeli face a very different set of problems. Fish catch, they say, is dwindling every passing day. "We go out to sea everyday but many days we return empty handed," said P. Murthy, while tending to his net. "The desalination plant next door has affected the catch," he says.

The fishermen had a message to the political parties: "We do not want anything for free. If at all, kindly make education and healthcare free, and then watch the country progress."

The AIADMK had a strong presence in the coastal belt since MGR's times, but the electorate has now fragmented with relatively newer players such as the Naam Tamilar Katchi garnering votes, Mr. Rajaram said, adding that the advent of actor Vijay-led Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam has had an appeal among the youth.

In the rest of the constituency, caste equations are quite well laid out: while it has a sizeable Vanniyar population, the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes also make up a considerable proportion of the population. It was a reserved constituency between 1977 and 2006. However, the urbanised part of the constituency could upset caste equations.

SRM Global Hospitals performs dual surgery on pregnant woman

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A team of doctors at the SRM Global Hospitals performed dual surgery on a pregnant woman and delivered the baby, saving the

specialists included obstetrician and gynaecologist R.K. Vidhyalakshmi, Clinical Haematology consultant D. Abinaya, Neonatology consultant C. Ashok, and Anaesthesiology consultant R. Shanmitha.

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

MY DAUGHTER Netania, born on 01 September 2014 (District of Birth: Chennai), residing at No.63, Vaiko Street, Rajiv Gandhi Nagar, Pattabram, Chennai- 600062, shall henceforth be known as New Given Name: Netania, New Surname: Kumar Raj - Kumar Raj (Father)

I, BALAJI Chinnasamy Kuppusamy, residing at No 151 MIG, NH1, Vallal Kumanan Street, Maraimalai Nagar - 603209. My Name entered in Aadhar Card No.5896 3889 3056 is as Balaji Chinnasamy Kuppusamy and My name entered in my passport No.F 8140943 is as Balajee Chinnaswamy Kuppusamy. Denotes and refers the same single person as Balaji Chinnasamy Kuppusamy, Vide affidavit dt. 24.03.2026

I, SOWDHAMINI, d/o Govindaraju born on 22 Apr 1984 residing at No. 32, Perumal Koli Street, Nazarethpuram, Chennai - 600016, have changed my name to Sowdhmini Udhayakumar vide affidavit dated 25 Mar 2026 at Chennai

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Two persons killed after truck hits two-wheeler

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two persons were killed after a heavy truck hit their two-wheeler on Palar bridge near Maduranthakam on Wednesday.

A senior police official of Chengalpattu district said Abinеш and Charles were residents of Avadi and were travelling on the two-wheeler to Puducherry on the Grand Southern Trunk (GST) Road.

Attempt to overtake

As the vehicle was proceeding on the Palar bridge, a speeding truck knocked down the vehicle while attempting to overtake them.

In the impact, both persons were thrown-off from the vehicle and were killed on the spot after sustaining severe head and body injuries. The driver of the truck escaped from the spot. The Padalam police sent the bodies of the two persons to Chengalpattu Government hospital for a post-mortem. A probe has been launched and the police are searching for the truck driver.

CMRL begins tunnelling for Thiruvannmiyur-Indira Nagar section in phase-II project

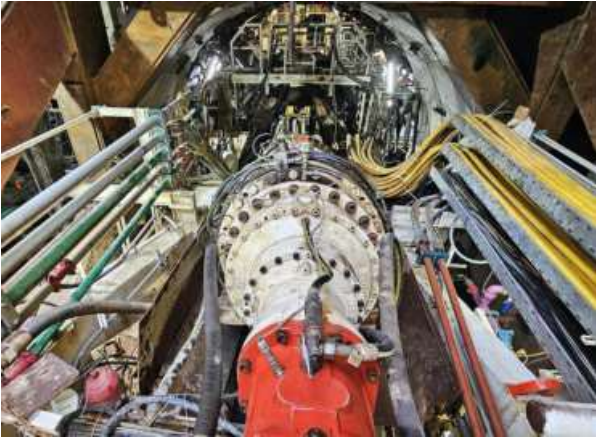
Tunnelling through hard rocks in the 650-metre stretch may take nearly six months, officials say; a specialised TBM is being used in this section, which is part of the Madhavaram-SIPCOT corridor

TRACK TALES
Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

Chennai Metro Rail's tunnelling work from Thiruvannmiyur to Indira Nagar for the ongoing phase-II project has begun recently and the machine has drilled nearly 100 metres.

As part of the ₹63,246 crore project, three corridors—Madhavaram to SIPCOT (corridor 3), Light House to Poonamallee (corridor 4) and Madhavaram to Sholinganallur (corridor 5) are being constructed in most parts of the city for the past few years.

Under corridor 3, whose network is part elevated and part underground, much like the other two corridors, Chennai Metro Rail has been carrying out tunnelling work for



Hard task: The second Tunnel Boring Machine can be launched at Thiruvannmiyur only after the first TBM reaches Indira Nagar.

building the underground stretches in small sections. The tunnelling in one small section of this corridor 3, Thiruvannmiyur to Indira Nagar, commenced recently. According to officials of Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), the shaft of the station, which has to be built only after which a Tunnel Boring Machine (TBM) can be lowered and

launched, was ready and subsequently the machine began the drilling process. For this stretch dominated by high-quality hard rocks, a TBM specialised for operating in such conditions is being utilised. Officials said tunnelling through the 650-metre stretch between Thiruvannmiyur and Indira Nagar could be tough and rather

slow due to geological conditions, and it would probably require changing the parts of the TBM like the cutterhead more often than expected.

"We estimate that it may take nearly six months for this TBM to reach Indira Nagar. Due to site related constraints, the second TBM can be launched at Thiruvannmiyur only after the first TBM reaches Indira Nagar," an official said.

As such, the tunnelling work has been delayed quite a bit. At first, CMRL cancelled the tenders which were floated for the underground work since firms that were part of bidding submitted unreasonable quotes.

Excavating the station area and building the shaft too was difficult owing to hard rocks. Instead of controlled blasting, the contractor ended up disintegrating the rock with chemicals.

VCK chief urges Stalin to ensure Makkal Needhi Maiam contests upcoming Assembly election

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A day after Makkal Needhi Maiam (MNM) founder and Rajya Sabha MP Kamal Haasan announced that his party would not contest the upcoming Assembly election, Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) founder and Chidambaram MP Thol. Thirumavalavan, on Wednesday, appealed to Chief Minister M.K. Stalin to realise the alliance's "We will win together" slogan by ensuring the MNM fights the election under its own 'Battery Torch' symbol.

In a statement, Mr. Thirumavalavan said that the MNM not taking an active

role in the election and supporting the alliance from outside will affect the "goodwill" of the alliance.

Mr. Thirumavalavan added that parties in alliance should not be compelled to "contest under the symbol" of another party. "This would hinder their independent political functioning. The alliance leadership refraining from interfering in such freedom of allied parties would be a mark of respect for democracy. In this critical situation, in this righteous struggle to defeat communal, divisive, and right-wing forces, Makkal Needhi Maiam too must join hands with us and contest the election as a partici-

pant like us," he said.

Mr. Thirumavalavan said that the strength of a party "does not solely correlate to its vote bank" but also on factors such as ideological strength and public goodwill. "Let it be considered his [Mr. Kamal Haasan] magnanimity that Makkal Needhi Maiam has decided not to contest this election. However, it would be a mark of your greatness to embrace Mr. Kamal Haasan – who possesses ideological strength in firmly opposing communalism, a confirmed vote bank strength of around 4%, and great influence and goodwill within Tamil society – and not let him remain outside," he said.

Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust launches school project for holistic education

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In an effort to support holistic education, the Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust inaugurated the School Expansion and Modernisation Project at Satyamurthi Higher Secondary School in Chennai on Wednesday.

Value-based learning

Established at a cost of ₹16 crore the project has been

designed to combine academics with opportunities in science, sports, arts, and value-based learning.

The school includes modern classrooms, science laboratories, a STEM learning facility, sports infrastructure, and a large auditorium for cultural and other activities. The project marks an important milestone in the institution's efforts to provide quality and holistic

education to children from disadvantaged backgrounds as well as the surrounding community, according to a press release.

The project was done with support from Braade Stiftung (Denmark), Saint-Gobain India Pvt Ltd, Aptus Value Housing Finance India Ltd and Boeing India Pvt Ltd and others. Praveena Yagnambhat, Chief of Staff and CSR Head, Boeing India and South Asia, K.G.

Venkataramanan, Chief Financial Officer, Saint-Gobain India Private Limited (SGIPL) and Maya Gaitonde, Honorary General Secretary and Trustee, Bala Mandir Kamaraj Trust were present at the inauguration.

The Bala Mandir Schools currently have around 400 students and aim to expand capacity to about 800 students in the coming years.

Kerala man found dead in forest near Anaikatti

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

The Thadagam police police have launched an investigation after a man from Sholayur in Kerala's Palakkad district was found dead in suspicious circumstances in a reserve forest area near Anaikatti in Coimbatore.

The deceased has been identified as M. Mayilan, 56, a resident of Vechapathy. The Forest Department staff found a decomposed male body at Kozhikandimoolai during routine patrol on Monday and alerted the Thadagam police station.

A mobile phone found on the body was identified to be that of Mayilan. The Thadagam police launched an investigation into the death, after registering a case on Tuesday for suspicious death based on a complaint from the deceased's son Manikandan, 25. As per post-mortem findings, the body had multiple injuries, the police said.

Meanwhile, Forest Department officials raised suspicions on why Mayilan entered the reserve forest area in Tamil Nadu side, located over 20 km away from his village. They stated that a person by the same name from Sholayur had been involved in sandalwood felling cases in Coimbatore district before.

**KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD**
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 and 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar, Bengaluru - 560009. Phone No. 080-22265383, website: www.kiadb.in

No. IADB/ENGG/ETND-DPR-08/4082/2025-26 **Date: 25.03.2026**

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

KIADB invites tenders from reputed consultants/firms under two cover bid system having an office at Bengaluru with vast experience and proven record of similar nature of work for project mentioned below:-
Name of the works : Consultancy Services for Preparation of Detailed Project Report (DPR) Including Economic Analysis, Surveying, Layout Plan, Design, Preparation of Estimates, Cost Structure etc., for the proposed Jangamakote Industrial Area at Sidlaghatta Taluk of Chikkaballapura District. (Extent 2823.12 A). (3rd-Call).
The last date and time of receipt of tender is : **10.04.2026 upto 4.00 pm.**
Applicants May Download Bidding Documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement Portal **https://kpppp.karnataka.gov.in.**

Sd/-
Chief Engineer-1, KIADB, Bengaluru

DIPR/CP/6462/Zen/2025-26

**BENGALURU SOLID WASTE MANAGEMENT LIMITED**
Office of the Deputy General Manager-1,BSWML, 1st Floor, BBMP Building, Thimmaiah Road, Vasanth Nagar, Bengaluru – 560 052.

No: DGM-1/BSWML/TEND/32/2025-26 **Date: 25.03.2026**

Invitation for Short Term Tender
(Through GOK KPPP only) (Call-03)

The Deputy General Manager-1, Bengaluru Solid Waste Management Limited on behalf of the Managing Director, BSWML, Bengaluru invites bids from eligible bidders for the Services mentioned in the table given below.

Sl. No.	Name of the work	Amount Put to Tender per annum (Rs. in Lakhs)	EMD (Amount in Rs.)	Time of Completion
1	Primary Collection and Secondary Transportation of Municipal solid waste (MSW) and Street sweeping waste in Shanthi Nagara division (Package-02) Call-03.	1,411.47	Rs.1,00,000/- through e-payment mode under of the following i.e., online / RTGS/ NEFT / OTC and the balance Rs.14,00,000/- by bank Guarantee/FDR issued by Nationalized/Scheduled Bank.	84 Months

1) Last date for uploading Pre-bid Queries : **31.03.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** 2) Tender Pre-Bid meeting : **01.04.2026 at 15:00 hrs** at above mentioned office. 3) Last Date of Receipt of Tender: **10.04.2026 before 17:30 hrs.** 4) Opening of Technical Bid: **13.04.2026 after 17:30 hrs.**
More details can be downloaded from website - **https://kpppp.karnataka.gov.in**

Sd/-
Deputy General Manager-1, BSWML

DIPR/CP/JA/6328/2025-26

NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
SECOND CORRIGENDUM
TO THE E-TENDER NOTICE T.No. JU/Const/ T-04- 2025-26-BGKT-PH-II, dated 07.03.2026
In the aforesaid e-tender, the definition of similar nature of work has been changed, which is as under-
"Any Civil Engineering work involving construction of buildings, fabrication and erection of Industrial shed of height not less than 10 m using Pre-Engineered Building (PEB) with EOT crane of minimum 25 MT Capacity including foundation work for the shed."
All other particulars of the original Tender Notice will remain same.
Dy. Chief Engineer (Const), J. Jodhpur
428-DR/26

Govt. of Bihar

Civil Aviation Department
Airport Road, Patna – 800014.

TEL No:- 0612-2225659, 2224423
Fax 0612 2224614
e-mail-cadbihar@bihar.gov.in

Letter. No: वा०सा०नि० (मोजना) 09-17 / 2025 - 406

TENDER NOTICE

Civil Aviation Department, Govt. of Bihar invites Tender in two cover bid system for Selection of Air Services to New International Destinations.
Eligible bidders can submit their responses to the tender on or before **15th April, 2026, 15:00 Hrs.** Details of Schedule is as below:-

1.	Bid subject/work	:	Selection of Air Services to New International Destinations
2.	Bid Submission Start Date	:	25 th March, 2026
3.	Pre- Bid Meeting (Virtual Mode)	:	7 th April, 2026 at 12.30 PM (Link will be shared)
4.	Last date for submission of Bid	:	15 th April, 2026, by 15:00 Hrs.
5.	Technical Bid Opening	:	16 th April, 2026, at 15:30 Hrs. (Tentative date)
6.	Financial Bid Opening	:	Shall be intimated
7.	Tender Bid Validity	:	120 Days

The tender document(s), may be downloaded free of cost from the Civil Aviation Department, Govt. of Bihar website (<https://state.bihar.gov.in/cad>).

PR- 27249 (C A D) 2025-26 **Secretary**
नशे की मार, बर्बाद करे सुखी परिवार। **Civil Aviation Department**

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**மீதமிதமிதம்**

From Page One

No major surprises as AIADMK releases its first list of candidates

In the 2021 election, Mr. Rajenthra Bhalaji and Mr. Shanmugam lost from Rajapalayam and Vilupuram respectively, while Mr. Krishnamurthy won in Polur.

The party's deputy general secretaries K.P. Munusamy and Natham R. Viswanathan have been fielded again from their respective constituencies: Veppannahalli and Natham.

The renominated candidates include treasurer Dindigul C. Sreenivasan (Dindigul); headquarters secretary S.P. Velumani (Thondamuthur); and organisation secretaries P. Thangamani (Kumarapalayam), D. Jayakumar (Royapuram), Sellur K. Raju (Madurai-West), K.P. Anbalagan (Palacode), R. Kamaraj (Nannilam), and O.S. Manian (Vedaranyam).

Former Health Minister C. Vijayabaskar will try his luck again in Viralmalai; Kadambur C. Raju in Kovilpatti; R.B. Udhayakumar in Thirumangalam; P. Benjamin in Maduravoyal; and V.V. Rajan Chellappa in Thirupparankundram.

Three other former Ministers – K.C. Karuppanan, K.C. Veeramani, and M.R. Vijayabhaskar – will contest from Bhavani, Jolarpet, and Karur respectively, while former government whip in the Assembly, S. Rajendran, has been re-nominated to contest from Ariyalur.

Despite losing the previous election from their respective constituencies, Mr. Jayakumar, Mr. Benjamin, Mr. Veeramani, and Mr. Rajendran have been fielded from the same constituencies again.

Of the 27 seats the BJP will contest this time, the organisation is familiar with eight seats, where nominees from the same coalition contested in 2021. The constituencies are: Tiruvannamalai, Thalli, Modakurichi, Udthagamandalam, Nagercoil, Vilavancode, Ramanathapuram, and Colachel.

The remaining 19 seats are Mylapore, Avadi, Rasipuram, Avanashi, Tiruppur (South), Coimbatore (North), Gandarvakottai, Pudukottai, Thanjavur, Tiruvavur, Tirupattur (Sivaganga district), Madurai (south), Sattur, Tiruchendur, Vasudevanallur, Radhapuram, Aranthangi, Manamadurai, and Padmanabhapuram.

Nagenthran's move
Interestingly, Tirunelveli Assembly constituency, which was won by BJP State president Nainar Nagenthran, is not among the list of seats being contested by the national party. Mr. Nagenthran is likely to contest from Sattur Assembly constituency in Virudhunagar district.

AIADMK-led alliance will win 210 seats, says Palaniswami

Launching his campaign in Mylapore, AIADMK leader says NDA will form the government with an absolute majority; he accuses DMK of not fulfilling its promises and failing on law and order front

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Launching his election campaign from Mylai Mangollai in Chennai on Wednesday, AIADMK general secretary and former Chief Minister Edappadi K. Palaniswami said the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance would win 210 seats and form the government with an absolute majority.

Campaigning in Mylapore, a constituency allotted to the BJP, he appeared alongside BJP leader and former Governor of Telangana, Tamilisai Soundararajan, despite the fact that the BJP is yet to officially announce her candidature. In 2001, the BJP had won the constituency when the DMK was in an alliance with the BJP-led NDA.

Earlier, Mr. Palaniswami, accompanied by party cadre, visited the Kapaleeswarar Temple in Mylapore and offered special prayers at the temple.

Alliance comparison
Comparing his alliance with the DMK-led front, Mr. Palaniswami said the condition of the DMK was pitiable.

“Three days ago, we invited our alliance partners to our party office and announced the seat allocations. The very next day, we released our election manifesto. Since our manifesto benefits the people, it is being widely appreciated. Similarly, we held discussions with leaders of



In poll mode: AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami and BJP leader Tamilisai Soundararajan campaigning in Chennai on Wednesday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

the alliance parties and finalised the seat-sharing arrangement. Not only that, the AIADMK has also released its first list of candidates. We are the first party to make such an announcement. We have released a list of 23 candidates,” he said. He added that the remaining candidates would be announced in a couple of days.

“The alliance parties in the DMK struggled for 20 days just to form an alliance. Every party is struggling in the alliance, and they are forced to fight even to secure constituencies. The DMK alliance parties are treated like subordinates, whereas the AIADMK alliance leaders function independently,” Mr. Palaniswami said.

Claiming that the DMK government had done nothing for the people in the past five years, he said, “The DMK is a family-run

party driven by dynastic politics, and they have merely rebranded the AIADMK's schemes. The storm-water drain project was initiated during the AIADMK's tenure, with 2,400 km having been covered. Phases 1 and 2 were completed under AIADMK rule, while phases 3 and 4 remain incomplete under the DMK government. Two years ago, [Chief Minister] Stalin and city officials claimed that Chennai would not face water stagnation. Yet, flooding persists.”

“Ahead of the last Assembly polls, the DMK made 525 promises but fulfilled not even a quarter of them. Yet, they falsely claim that 98% of the promises have been fulfilled. Did they waive education loans? Did they abolish NEET? They misled people and students with false assurances. Taxes have in-

creased drastically – property tax by 100%, commercial tax by 150%, and electricity tariff by 52%. The cost of living has skyrocketed, and the government has failed to control prices. Under the AIADMK regime, a ₹100-crore price stabilisation fund ensured that essential commodities remained affordable. But the DMK has shown no concern on this front,” he said.

Alleging that drug abuse was rampant, leading to crime, and that law and order had deteriorated, he said murders, robberies, and assaults were occurring frequently. “Women's safety has been severely compromised, with thousands of POCSO cases having been registered. Such a government must be removed. The AIADMK-led alliance must win decisively to restore law and order,” Mr. Palaniswami said.

Build consensus with transpersons before passing amendment Bill, CM tells Centre

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Wednesday said the Union government should not impose the proposed amendments to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019, on the community.

In a post on X, Mr. Stalin said the amendment Bill cannot be pushed through without listening to the very people whose rights and lives it would affect.

The BJP government at the Centre must pause, engage, and build consensus with transpersons before moving forward with the changes, he added.



M.K. Stalin

Cylinder shortage
Instead of taking measures to resolve the shortage of cooking gas cylinders due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, the BJP government at the Centre was using delimitation to divert the attention of the people, Mr. Stalin said.

In a statement, he said that by equating the shortage in supply of cooking gas cylinders to the period of the COVID-19 pandemic, Prime Minister Narendra Modi had heightened fear among people, who were already suffering.

“In line with the BJP, the AIADMK, which has effectively silenced itself from speaking about people's issues, is questioning what the State government is doing. Is the supply of gas cylinders and foreign policy under the control of the State government,” he asked.

“The State government has taken all possible measures in its capacity. The question being raised by the people is what the Union government is doing,” he said.

Since attempts to create divisions among the constituents of the Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA) had failed, conspiracies criticising the seat-sharing arrangements were being circulated “based on imagination”, Mr. Stalin said.

In a letter to party workers, he urged them to ignore rumours intended at misleading them, and to work together with allies to ensure victory in all 234 Assembly segments.

As new parties had joined the alliance, seats had to be allocated accordingly among the constituents, Mr. Stalin said, adding that he personally held talks with leaders of some of the parties that had been part of the DMK-led alliance for a long time.

He said the DMK and its alliance partners stood united in opposing the communal politics of the BJP government at the Centre.

AIADMK allots 11 seats reserved for Scheduled Castes to its allies

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The AIADMK has allotted 11 constituencies reserved for the Scheduled Castes to its allies.

Five of them – Avanashi, Rasipuram, Gandarvakottai, Vasudevanallur, and Manamadurai – have been earmarked for the BJP; three – Periyakulam, Ottapidaram, and Poonamallee – for the AMMK; and two – Kattumannarkoil and Kilvelur – for the PMK.

Kilvaithinankuppam (K.V. Kuppam) has been allotted to the Puratchi Bharatham.

In total, there are 44 SC constituencies in Tamil Nadu.

In addition to the two SC seats, the PMK has been allocated Perambur, Ambattur, Thiruporur, Uthiramerur, Sholinghur, Polur, Gingee, Vriddhachalam, Rishivandhiyam, Vikravandi, Dharmapuri, Pennaga-

Five of them – Avanashi, Rasipuram, Gandarvakottai, Vasudevanallur, and Manamadurai – have been earmarked for the BJP

ram, Salem (West), Salem (North), Mayiladuthurai, and Jayankondam.

In respect of the AMMK, the other seats allotted to it are Saidapet, Tirupattur (in northern Tamil Nadu), Madathukulam, Tiruchi (West), Mannargudi, Thiruvaiyaru, Karaikudi, and Nanguneri.

Ranipet, Kumbakonam, Oddanchatram, Erode (west), and Killiyoor have been given to the Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopannar); Pallavaram and Kunnam to the Indhiya Jananayaga Katchi; and Rajapalayam to the Tamizhaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam.

Releasing the list of constituencies identified for various constituents of the National Democratic Alliance (NDA), AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said all parties of the NDA were equally strong, and they were being treated equally in the alliance.

No party would come under any pressure to contest the election on the symbol of one party or the other, Mr. Palaniswami said.

PMK candidates
Meanwhile, the PMK announced that the party's general secretary, S. Vadivel Ravanan, will contest the Assembly election from the Kilvelur (SC) constituency; former State vice-president K.N. Sekar will be fielded from the Ambattur constituency, and former MLA A. Ganesh Kumar will enter the fray in the Gingee constituency.

SDPI, MJK, MPP get one seat each in DMK alliance

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI) led by V.M.S. Mohammed Mubarak, the Manithaneya Jananayaga Katchi (MJK) led by Thamimur Ansari, and the Mukkulathor Puli Padai (MPP) led by actor Karunas, have been allocated one seat each as part of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance for the upcoming Assembly election.

To use DMK symbol
The leaders of these parties held meetings with a DMK delegation at Anna Arivalayam, the ruling party's headquarters, in Chennai on Wednesday.

All these parties are set to contest the election on the DMK's ‘Rising Sun’ symbol, and their respective seats will be finalised on Thursday.

By not keeping his word, EPS has lost credibility, says OPS

The Hindu Bureau
BODINAYAKANUR

The people would not be carried away by the election manifesto of the AIADMK, as its general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami has lost credibility by not keeping his word, former Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam, who recently joined the DMK, said on Wednesday.

Addressing the media, Mr. Panneerselvam said that 10 consecutive elections since the R.K. Nagar byelection in 2017 had proved that Mr. Palaniswami lacked personality and efficiency. “Tall leaders such as M. Karunanidhi and Jayalalithaa too had faced defeats in elections. However, they had a great personality, which ensured that they made a quick comeback,” he said.

He ridiculed Mr. Palaniswami for claiming that he was leading the National



Panneerselvam ridiculed AIADMK leader Palaniswami for claiming that he was leading the NDA in Tamil Nadu. FILE PHOTO

Democratic Alliance (NDA) in Tamil Nadu. “If that were the case, the smaller parties should contest the election on the AIADMK's symbol and not the BJP's,” he said. He claimed that AIADMK members had switched to the DMK en masse.

“The people would not believe the AIADMK's promises of ₹2,000 in monthly assistance to women and refrigerators to all ration cardholders. The DMK has

fulfilled all of its poll promises, and has even implemented schemes that were not promised during the last election campaign,” he said.

“When the DMK manifesto is announced, all political parties will run away (from the electoral arena),” he said. Chief Minister M.K. Stalin was working to spread industrialisation across the southern districts to generate job opportunities, he added.

Holidays cut nomination window to four days

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Election Commission of India (EC) on Wednesday said nominations for the upcoming Assembly election in Tamil Nadu could be filed between March 30, the date of notification, and April 6, the last date for receipt of nominations.

However, since four public holidays fall during this period, there are effectively only four days for filing nominations.

According to an official press release, nominations could be filed between 11 a.m. and 3 p.m. Since March 31, April 1, April 3, and April 5 have been declared public holidays under the Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881, nominations will not be received on these dates.

No need for govt. sanction to register FIR on alleged scam in K.N. Nehru's dept., A-G tells HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Advocate-General P.S. Raman on Wednesday informed the Madras High Court of having given a legal opinion that there is no need for the State government to grant sanction to the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti Corruption (DVAC) for registering an FIR in connection with an alleged cash-for-jobs scam in Minister K.N. Nehru's Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department.

Appearing before the first Division Bench of Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan, the A-G said he had opined that it would be sufficient if the DVAC just informs the State government, and that it need not seek sanction, as required under Section 17 of the Prevention of Corruption Act, before commencing any inquiry against public servants when the High Court had ordered the registration of the FIR.

The A-G said he had also

opined that in instances where constitutional courts had ordered registration of FIR in corruption cases, the government had no option but to just record the fact.

Contempt plea
The submissions were made during the hearing of a contempt of court petition filed by All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK) Rajya Sabha member I.S. Inbadurai for non-compliance with the court order.

While allowing a writ



K.N. Nehru

petition filed by the Member of Parliament, former Chief Justice Manindra Mohan Shrivastava and Justice

The A-G said he had opined that it would suffice if the DVAC informs the State government

Murugan had, on February 20, ordered registration of the FIR “forthwith” regarding the alleged scam. Since the direction was not complied with, the MP had filed the contempt of court petition against the then DVAC chief on February 26.

During the course of the

hearing of the contempt plea, the Bench led by Chief Justice Dharmadhikari expressed its displeasure over the DVAC not having registered the FIR till date, in spite of a specific judicial direction.

“As on date, the order is staring at you. You either comply with the order or take it on appeal. You cannot simply keep it in a limbo. Our order is very clear. You cannot frustrate the order,” Justice Murugan said.

However, the A-G replied that the State govern-

ment had filed a review petition against that order as early as on February 26, but it was yet to get numbered. He said that the review petition had been filed on eight elaborately drafted grounds, and that the petition was about to get numbered on Monday (March 23), but it did not happen as the case bundles had been shifted from one section to another in the Registry.

More time sought
He urged the court to grant him some time for getting

the review petition numbered and listed before the Division Bench.

On his part, senior counsel N.R. Elango, representing the DVAC, said the agency was ready with its counter-affidavit to the contempt plea, and advocate Avinash Motwani, representing the MP, urged the court to take up the contempt petition as well as the review petition for hearing together.

After hearing all of them, the judges adjourned the matter for further hearing to April 20.



Welfare and distress

The Opposition is trying to undermine the LDF's development pitch

Kerala stands on the threshold of a high-stakes election on April 9 which could mark an inflection point in the State's electoral history. In 2021, the Left Democratic Front (LDF) led by the CPI(M), which broke tradition with its consecutive win, now seeks a third term. But it is beset by a slew of allegations, rebellion in its ranks and high-profile defections to the Congress and the BJP. This election, therefore, unfolds on a very different political terrain. The Congress-led United Democratic Front is counting on a perceptible undercurrent of anti-incumbency, the signs of which were evident when it outperformed the LDF in the December 2025 local body elections; it notched up a vote share of 38.8% against the LDF's 33.4% and won most local bodies. The Congress-led alliance has fielded a handful of Left leaders who had defected, causing agony to its cadres in some seats even as it was set back by senior leader K. Sudhakaran's mutiny during candidate selection. The Congress is seeking to counter the Left's development rhetoric by offering its own welfare schemes, aimed at women and youth. Attempting to queer the pitch in the bipolar polity is the BJP-led National Democratic Alliance, which wrested the Thiruvananthapuram Municipal Corporation from the Left Front in the local body elections in December 2025 through deft election engineering. But its vote share dropped to 14.7% from 19.2% in 2024 when it made its Lok Sabha debut from Kerala. Aiming to build on what it sees as a gradual shift in the political landscape, the BJP has drawn a few disenchanted leaders from both major coalitions and broadbased its reach by aligning with emerging outfits such as Twenty20, which claims a foothold in parts of central Kerala. The alliance is also attempting to expand its reach into minority communities, particularly among Catholic Christians in central Travancore.

The ruling coalition has largely retained its incumbent legislators, projecting continuity and seeking to rebut claims of anti-incumbency. It is also banking on its decade-long development welfare initiatives while attempting to capitalise on perceived uncertainties in the Congress over its chief ministerial candidate. Beyond the familiar rhetoric of development, a complex interplay of factors, with demographics being a key variable, will likely determine the outcome in each constituency. Foremost is the alignment of Kerala's two major religious minorities, Muslims and Christians, who constitute nearly 47% of the electorate. A range of issues, from the Union government's approach to the State, the Sabarimala god theft, concerns over land encroachment to agrarian distress and debates around political Islam, is expected to shape voter sentiment.

Cuban sorrow

The U.S. asphyxiation of Cuba demands global condemnation

Even as the world is feeling the pinch of the ill-thought-out and cruel attacks by the United States and its West Asian loose-cannon ally, Israel, on Iran, an equally heinous imperial act is under way in the Caribbean, drawing little attention. The Trump administration has effectively blockaded Cuba's fuel supplies to pressure regime change. In actions taken since December 2025, interdicting Venezuelan oil shipments, threatening punitive tariffs on any country supplying fuel and deterring Russian diesel and crude oil supplies, the U.S. has strangled a petroleum-dependent country, where oil drives 83% of power generation. The consequences have been devastating. There have been three grid collapses in March 2026, even as garbage is piling up in Havana and other cities, perishable food is rotting, and industry and government offices have shut. Donald Trump's actions are criminally illegal by international law. He claims that Cuba is "seeing the end", boasts that he will have the "honour" of "taking" Cuba, and has called on the Cuban government to "make a deal before it's too late", without specifying any terms.

The actions against Cuba must be seen against a six-decade long U.S. embargo – but what Cubans term a blockade – ever since the revolution nationalised U.S.-owned enterprises in the early 1960s. The U.S.'s trade embargo in 1962 was progressively strengthened as the Helms-Burton Act of 1996 effectively conscripted the global business community into enforcing it. Meanwhile, Cuba's designation as a state sponsor of terrorism – removed by Barack Obama but restored by Mr. Trump and lacking any rational basis – has cut the country off from international banking. That these coercive measures persisted much after the Cold War reveals that their true purpose is not U.S. national security, but the appeasement of the right-wing Cuban-American community in Florida, led by U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio, son of Cuban émigrés, for whom regime change in Havana is a lifelong ambition. Mr. Trump's military intervention in Venezuela, including capturing a sitting President and seizing control of its oil, was itself partly designed to sever Cuba's primary fuel lifeline under the doctors-for-fuel arrangement. The pattern is clear: impunity in Venezuela emboldened the Trump administration to asphyxiate Cuba and impunity in Cuba has accompanied America's war on Iran. Each unchallenged act of imperial overreach normalises the next, threatening not just vulnerable nations in the U.S. orbit but also the very framework of international order. The world, including India, must not remain silent and have the gump-tion to condemn these actions and provide humanitarian assistance, under the aegis of the United Nations, for the people of Cuba.

The Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026 (Bill No. 79 of 2026), introduced in the Lok Sabha on March 13, 2026, makes several sharp changes to the 2019 Act. It narrows the definition of "transgender person" to only specific socio-cultural identities such as kinner, hijra, aravani, jogta, eunuch, or biologically-defined intersex variations, or persons forcibly compelled into such an identity through mutilation, castration, amputation, or any surgical, chemical or hormonal procedure. It explicitly excludes persons with different sexual orientations and non-heteronormative gender fluid identities.

The Bill removes the right to "self-perceived gender identity" from Section 4(2), replaces the simple District Magistrate process with a medical board "authority" headed by a Chief Medical Officer, and mandates hospitals to report every transgender surgery to the District Magistrate and the authority.

Perpetuating structural problems

The government claims that the new amendments fix the vagueness and implementation failures of the 2019 Act. Every year, thousands of intersex infants are killed or undergo medically unethical, non-consensual sex-selective surgeries that mutilate their bodies without regard for lifelong physical and psychological trauma, all in pursuit of a false "normalcy". Millions of intersex individuals remain ghosts in our Census systems, their births and deaths unregistered, rendering them invisible to legal protections and social services.

Even the highest authorities fail to grasp the fundamental distinctions between sex identity and gender identity, or between intersex variations and transgender identities, which fuels rampant discrimination. The Bill itself refers to male and female as "gender identity", which is fundamentally wrong – male and female are sex identities. By clubbing sex identity under the gender column, the Bill creates new problems where it is meant to solve existing ones.

The government does not have reliable data on transgender and intersex persons in India. They want to grant us rights but do not know who we are. Separating sex and gender identity as different categories on official documents would address the root causes of this problem.

Despite the new wording, the Bill still lumps "persons with intersex variations" inside the definition of a "transgender person." The term "transgender persons" often conflates distinct identities. The Trans Act's definition includes persons with intersex variations under "transgender", which erases intersex-specific needs. Intersex is a natural biological spectrum (recorded 1%-2% globally). Transgender identity is a psychological and social construct.



Gopi Shankar Madurai

Special Monitor for Sexual Orientation, Gender Identity and Expression and Sexual Characteristics (SOGIESC) Rights, National Human Rights Commission of India

The Bill only deepens the conflation of gender identities and ignores core crises

Retaining this conflation under one label violates rights under Article 21 to bodily integrity and privacy. It leaves out intersex infants without any specific ban on "normalising" surgeries and ignores repeated calls for separate intersex legislation.

The Bill's definition also contradicts established international standards: the United Nations and the World Health Organization define intersex as innate variations in sex characteristics that do not fit typical male or female binaries, requiring distinct legal recognition and explicit protections against non-consensual medical interventions. By forcing intersex persons into a transgender category, the Bill undermines these global definitions and erodes the very human rights framework that India has committed to uphold.

The Bill leaves the outdated title, National Council for Transgender Persons, and all State Welfare Boards unchanged. It ignores the long-standing proposal to rebrand them as a National GIESC Welfare Council and State GIESC Welfare Boards (GIESC is Gender Identity/Expression and Sex Characteristics). This keeps the entire policy architecture trapped under the problematic "transgender" umbrella instead of creating a scientifically accurate, inclusive framework. The government continues to promote a single identity at the national level.

This heteronormative bill erases the reality that GIESC communities, including transgender persons, may have diverse sexual orientations such as transgay, translesbian, transbisexual, or queer.

Legally empowering exploitative structures

New clauses in Section 18 introduce rigorous imprisonment (between five to 14 years) for forcing adults or children into "transgender presentation" plus begging or servitude. Yet, the Bill does nothing to regulate or dismantle the colonial hijra jamath-gharana system. By targeting only external perpetrators while leaving internal hierarchies untouched, the amendment effectively legitimises and empowers the long-standing hijra jamath-gharana system, codifying it into law. These structures are not inherently traditional; earlier Indic frameworks were more inclusive and rooted in a broader, affirmative understanding of diverse identities, free from later external influences.

At present, chief hijra nayaks control chelas' earnings from begging and prostitution, trapping gender non-conforming children (often abandoned) in bonded labour. Meanwhile, thousands of gender non-conforming children, abandoned or rejected by families, are thrust into exploitative hijra jamath gharanas, havelis, and dayars, where education is a distant dream; instead, and forced into begging and prostitution. State police often refuse to register missing

child complaints for gender non-conforming children, and there are no dedicated policies to address their vulnerability to trafficking and abuse. There is also no framework for reform, rehabilitation, or protection of minors within these systems. By protecting these colonial-era identities without evidence-based safeguards, the government is undermining earlier inclusive traditions.

The Bill contains no requirement for genetic counselling by medical geneticists before certification, intersex surgeries and health management. It offers no mandate for India-specific longitudinal studies on "affirming surgeries" and raises serious privacy concerns due to inadequate safeguards.

Instead of addressing the problems faced by diverse GIESC communities such as administrative barriers and unregulated medical practices which include gender-affirming surgeries and hormone therapies (Government of India promotes freely despite severe health risks) the Bill offers only superficial measures with little relevance to their needs. Despite the 2019 UN CRPD recommendations to prioritise intersex welfare and dignity, these concerns remain largely neglected.

No intersectionality

The Bill contains no intersectional lens for caste, disability, poverty or religion. Transgender persons from Scheduled Caste/Scheduled Tribe or disabled backgrounds will continue to face compounded discrimination with zero targeted remedies. It also fails to protect India's family-dependent societal structures by skipping any requirement for rigorous, evidence-based research before policy changes. Most critically, the Bill is completely silent on civil and marriage rights of diverse GIESC identities. It offers no provisions for marriage, adoption, inheritance, divorce, or succession for transgender persons, leaving them without full legal recognition in family law, and perpetuating their exclusion from the very institutions that define citizenship and dignity in Indian society.

The 2026 Amendment Bill tightens some definitions and increases penalties for forced exploitation, but leaves every core structural flaw untouched – the hetero-normative erasure of diverse SOGIESC identities, the complete neglect of civil and marriage rights, the legal entrenchment of colonial hijra structures at the expense of ancient Indic heritage. India needs a scientific, culturally grounded approach that separates biological sex characteristics from gender identity, prioritises evidence over ideology, bans non-consensual intersex surgeries, ensures equal rights, dismantles exploitative systems, and protects the dignity of intersex persons and gender non-conforming children. The Constitution demands nothing less.

Democracy, dissent and the 'national image' debate

The dramatic 'shirtless' protests by the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) at the India AI Impact Summit on February 20 triggered a debate on the limits of dissent and the response of the ruling party. As soon as the visuals of IYC workers going shirtless to protest the India-U.S. trade agreement went viral, several leaders from the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) were quick to describe it as an "anti-national" act and called Congress leader Rahul Gandhi a "traitor" who was determined to tarnish India's global image. The Delhi Police quickly filed charges, including rioting and promoting enmity between groups, and arrested 14 IYC members.

Does protesting against the government in front of international delegates at the AI summit dent the country's image? While there can be a debate on the manner of protests, it is not uncommon to find protesters at international events. Such protests are often seen as a demonstration of democratic credentials.

Perspective that might not sit well

In democracies, dissent is often considered a safety valve through which citizens not only express disapproval of a particular policy but also participate in the governance process. Such a view, however, does not fit well into the narrative of parties that seek to project strong and decisive leadership, where the personality and charisma of the leader drive the decision-making process.

In 1976, when former Prime Minister Indira Gandhi imposed the Emergency in the country, Congress president Dev Kanta Barooah had famously said, "India is Indira, Indira is India." Though no BJP leader has gone to the extent of equating Prime Minister Narendra Modi with the country, they routinely brand any serious criticism of him or his government as "an attack on the nation".

The projection of an all-pervasive leadership often blurs the line between the government and the state. In theory, though, there exists a clear one: the state is sovereign, permanent and supreme, while the government manages the



Sandeep Phukan

Democratic strength lies in engaging dissent without equating it to disloyalty to the nation

affairs of the state. The executive, or the government, is another organ of the state, just as the legislature and the judiciary are. In a democracy, the state would also include a healthy opposition that would provide the checks and balances.

How this distinction plays out in practice depends largely on the institutional design of the state, the distribution of power within it and how a ruling party frames its relationship with them.

Federal structure tensions

The concept of an all-pervasive "strong leader" necessarily leads to the notion of a strong state, where the distinction between dissent and sedition may dissolve. The extent to which this tendency manifests itself, however, is shaped by the constitutional arrangement of the state.

In the Indian context, the Constitution has been described as a document that is federal in structure and unitary in spirit. While there is a neat division of responsibilities in the central and the State Lists, the Union government has been accorded primacy in the Concurrent List – subjects over which both State governments and the Centre have jurisdiction.

Parties arguing for a "strong" state often adopt a reading of the Constitution that focuses on the unitary spirit of the document, and any contrarian position is viewed as an attempt to weaken the Centre. From this perspective, excessive regional assertions are sometimes seen as carrying the potential to encourage centrifugal tendencies.

Those who insist on the federal structure of the Constitution emphasise its pluralistic design, with different linguistic, cultural and ideological currents coexisting within the constitutional framework.

Political parties or ideologies alone do not shape our understanding of the state and the government; it is also influenced by the historical experience of the state with separatist movements and internal security challenges. Intelligence and security agencies prefer

political messaging through mass media that pushes towards creating a 'one nation, one identity' narrative. Such messaging not only reinforces a strong and powerful Centre but also acts as a safeguard against any centrifugal force.

And the mass media acts as a force multiplier, especially when political communication has become visual and performative. Every evening, TV anchors issue certificates of patriotism and sit in judgment on what constitutes an anti-national act. In doing so, they merge the line between the government and the country, often arguing that criticism, when amplified globally, are used by actors to question the legitimacy of the state.

Be it the protests against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act (CAA) in 2019 or the farmers' agitation of 2020-21, a large section of the mass media accused the protesters of playing into the hands of the forces that are inimical to the country. And, therefore, a protest against policy became a protest against the nation.

The tension between these two approaches reflects a deeper debate about the nature of nationalism in a democracy – whether unity is best preserved through a celebration of diversity or the assertion of a singular national identity.

Deeper questions

The debate sparked off by the IYC protests goes beyond what constitutes a 'decent' protest. It raises larger questions about how a democracy negotiates the space for dissent while maintaining national cohesion.

A confident nation derives its strength not merely from uniformity but also from its ability to accommodate competing voices within the constitutional framework, while remaining alert to attempts that may challenge the unity and integrity of the State.

The real test of democratic maturity lies not in the absence of dissent but in the willingness to engage with it without conflating criticism of the government with disloyalty to the nation.

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The war in West Asia

President Donald Trump's shifting ultimatums and abrupt reversals expose not strength, but confusion and desperation. His claims of "victory" ring hollow when Iran continues to retaliate effectively, holding its ground despite sustained military pressure. This is not

strategy. It is miscalculation of the highest order. Every act of aggression has been met with escalation, pushing the region closer to a catastrophic conflict. Such brinkmanship is not only irresponsible but deeply dangerous, with the global economy already paying the price. Equally, Israel's

continued strikes, enabled by U.S. backing, risk dragging the entire region into prolonged instability.

K.J. Haroon Basha,
Vaniyambadi, Tamil Nadu

This is an event with cascading second-order effects. Curtailment of gas to petrochemical units

threatens to choke the production of essential polymers, disrupting supply

chains that sustain everyday life, from food packaging to infrastructure

Corrections & Clarifications

A sentence in "India's dual dependence on West Asia for urea production" (Opinion page – "Data Point", March 23) should have read, "In 2025, India's urea imports exceeded \$2.3 billion, with a staggering 71% of these imports coming from West Asia (Chart 4)", and not "... exceeded 2,300 lakh metric tonnes, with a staggering ...".

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materials. Equally concerning is the vulnerability of semiconductor hubs. India must be prepared for deepening economic shock.

M. Jeyaram,
Sholavandan, Tamil Nadu

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

An energy transition driven by ethics

“Fossil fuel dependency is ripping away national security and sovereignty, and replacing it with subservience and rising costs,” UN climate change arm executive secretary Simon Stiell told European Union officials and ministers in Brussels on March 16, against the backdrop of the U.S.-Israel-Iran war. He added that the disruption serves as an “abject lesson” on the pitfalls of banking on fossil fuels.

The war in West Asia has disproportionately affected economies such as India which gets nearly 60% of its crude oil from the region. The closure of the Strait of Hormuz has forced state-run refineries to declare force majeure – an act of god. Pushing a country like India to abandon its remaining coal or domestic gas reserves without a take-off ramp could lead to industrial collapse.

Mr. Stiell’s comments are reminiscent of the expressions of impatience by climate negotiators and stakeholders about how slow countries have been to switch away from fossil fuels: in 2021, activist Greta Thunberg called the COP26 talks “blah, blah, blah”.

The West used fossil fuels to build its strategic reserves and today can’t deny India and other countries like it the same opportunities, especially as the latter waits for its renewables infrastructure to mature and expand. At the same time, India’s reliance on fossil fuels from West Asia is obviously why its economy is currently hostage to the region’s geopolitical crisis.

Dependence on minerals
Mr. Stiell et al. have argued that renewables are immune to such blockades, which is true in part: if the flow of fossil fuels stops today – it is pinched in the Strait of Hormuz – the ‘flow’ of energy also stops, because we burn fossil fuels to release energy. With renewables, the critical minerals are not the source of energy itself.



Vasudevan Mukunth

Short-term gains or geopolitical shocks should not dictate green energy shift

Once the state has set up solar panels and erected wind turbines, their ability to generate energy cannot be embargoed because they will operate as long as the sun shines and the wind blows.

However, critical minerals still represent a significant bottleneck, with additional complications such as the number of industries that need them – from consumer electronics to missile targeting, with the renewable energy sector somewhere in between. The supply chains for many minerals are even more concentrated than oil. The Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC+) controls around 40% of global oil production. And while the Democratic Republic of the Congo and Australia plus Chile extract most of the cobalt and lithium, respectively, a single country – China – currently processes almost 60% of the world’s lithium, 70% of its cobalt, and 90% of rare-earth elements.

With renewable energy also making intensive use of hardware, a blockade of the required components, whether it be turbine blades or magnets based on rare earth minerals, would be just as effective as one of oil. At that point, it is once again a question of whether war could break out between the world’s primary mineral-processing hubs.

Fossil versus mineral
The “abject lesson” is only so abject because of the prevailing oil situation. If, say, the West Asia conflict had not begun and Brent crude was \$65 a barrel, the trade-off for renewables could return to seeming like a moral luxury – in turn retrenching the value of ‘shock’ events like wars to push the world away from fossil fuels. And to that extent, perhaps Mr. Stiell et al. are smart to seize the chance.

Without a war driving prices up, the high upfront capital expenditure for renewables is less attractive to governments. If oil is cheap, the payback period for a large offshore wind farm might be

15 years; if gas prices jump 50%, this period could shrink to 4-5 years. In other words, sans a war, governments would have continued to place fiscal responsibility before energy sovereignty.

In the same scenario, the world’s dependencies on the critical mineral supply chain presents itself as a scarier prospect. If West Asia is stable and oil is flowing, the U.S. and its allies would likely view the option of trading West Asian oil for Chinese minerals as a net loss in strategic autonomy, which could encourage countries to reshore mineral mining and processing capabilities even before the energy transition picks up pace.

For India, a more stable supply of oil together with its arguably excessive focus on easing business could render its off-ramp into a long and gentle slope with room to continue using its domestic coal and cheap imported gas to power industrial growth while waiting for renewables to mature.

In other words, the Strait of Hormuz blockade could be forcing India to accelerate investments in renewables simply because it has no choice.

Fear not an effective tool
Mr. Stiell is in effect wielding fear as his primary tool, especially when he says “dependency is ripping away national security”. The effects of fear never last – especially when countries imagine new ways to outmanoeuvre these threats. What ultimately matters is ethics. The virtue of renewables should be debated, and adopted, in order to save the planet rather than for saving the economy for another month.

This also matters because when oil is cheap, the environmental damage of mining lithium, or human rights issues in Congolese cobalt mines are scrutinised more heavily by the public – and while this is as it should be, it should not just be because oil is cheap.

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Tidings from Kejriwal's comeback

The BJP will have to ensure that the ‘triple engine’ sarkar works efficiently

STATE OF PLAY

Jaideep Deo Bhanj
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As the extended celebrations by the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in Delhi, on completing one year in office, brings to an end its honeymoon phase, the focus of the government is on ensuring that the “triple engines” that run Delhi, work in tandem to deliver on the vision laid out by Prime Minister Narendra Modi of making Delhi a “world class” city.

With the arduous task of addressing legacy problems such as cleaning the Yamuna and fixing Delhi’s air pollution on the cards, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will have to reveal a clear blueprint of what her government plans to build, moving away from blaming the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) for “neglecting” Delhi’s development and finances for over a decade.

The return of Kejriwal
Coinciding with the end of the first year of the BJP government is also the return of former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal to Delhi’s political field, ending a self-imposed exile. After a Delhi Court discharged Mr. Kejriwal, his deputy Manish Sisodia and 21 others from a politically-charged liquor policy case, the former CM explained that he had decided to remain silent until he is proven innocent before the country, and when his *kattar imandar* (staunchly honest) credentials were back. With Mr. Kejriwal staying silent, senior AAP leaders busy in Punjab where it is in power, and the Leader of Opposition and former Chief Minister Atishi in-charge

of the AAP’s Goa unit, the role of the Opposition was being played by the AAP’s Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj.

Some leaders in the AAP say that the vacuum created by Mr. Kejriwal’s decision to step out of the limelight was deliberate so that the BJP could have a chance at governing Delhi. It would then turn up the heat once the party starts failing to deliver its promises.

Mr. Kejriwal’s return acquires significance as his political persona has been built on opposition – opposition to entrenched power, to central authority, and to what he calls bureaucratic overreach. Even when in power, frequent run-ins with the Lieutenant Governor (L-G) and the Union government had him fighting against the tide. How Mr. Kejriwal leads his party on its home turf as the Opposition is sure to keep the BJP guessing his next move.

However, the political impact of the allegations against Mr. Kejriwal will not be easy to erase. Crores of public money spent on renovating the official residence allotted to him, that the BJP has mockingly called the ‘Sheesh Mahal’, has tarnished the original image that he created of being a politician that will shun VIP treatment when he comes to power. Mr. Kejriwal will have to curate a comeback from controversy if he wants to carry on with his original mission.

Adding to this mix is the entry of former bureaucrat-diplomat Taranjit Singh Sandhu as Delhi’s new L-G. He is seen as someone the Centre has brought in to help the first time Chief Minister in a city that has a large diplomatic community. Mr. Sandhu who served as the Indian Ambassador to the U.S between 2020-2024, joined the BJP on March 19, 2024 and contested unsuccessfully from the Amritsar constituency in Punjab in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections.

His predecessor V.K Saxena’s tenure was marked by frequent run-ins with Mr. Kejriwal who accused him of stalling development in the capital. A less confrontational relationship between the Chief Minister and the L-G will see files move faster in the national capital territory.

The road ahead
The Delhi government in its first year has mostly relied on implementing central government schemes like the Ayushman Bharat, or modifying welfare schemes to introduce Arogya Mandirs as an alternative to the AAP’s Mohalla Clinic scheme, or replacing the AAP’s schools of specialised education with the CM Shri Schools.

There has been careful compliance, with the Centre and the Chief Minister not going off-script.

The BJP, for its part, is unlikely to cede ground easily to the AAP but it will have to prove that Delhi benefits from aligning with the Centre, particularly in areas requiring large-scale coordination and resources. Will Delhi’s “triple engine” government generate enough power to change the face of the capital? Or will it idle away the next four years allowing the AAP to reclaim its space?

Rural Telangana’s verdict on the Congress, BRS and BJP

Defections, pro-incumbency, and better performance among the tribals were factors which aided the Congress’ victory in the local body elections

DATA POINT

Pradeep Kumar Dontha
Vignesh Karthik K.R.

In December 2025, Telangana’s ruling Congress swept the rural body local polls, winning 53.7% of gram panchayats. This analysis maps every one of those 12,702 results individually to their Assembly Constituencies (ACs), mandals, and reservation categories, covering 94 rural/semi-urban ACs and 590 mandals. The party inclination of each sarpanch was gathered through district-level reporters on the ground; and the reservation category of each seat was sourced from the Telangana State Election Commission. Together, these two data streams make it possible to read the results not just by party aggregate but by geography, community category, and the specific context of each constituency.

While the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) held 27.7% panchayats, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) managed 5.5%, and the remaining went to smaller parties, independents, and rebels. Mapped to ACs, the Congress led in 83 of the 94 rural/semi-urban ACs, the BRS in 8, the BJP in 2, and others in 1. At the mandal level, the Congress led in 445 of the 590 seats (**Table 1**). The sweep extended well beyond the 62 out of 94 rural/semi-urban ACs the Congress won in 2023.

The defection factor
The single most revealing pattern in the data is the effect of MLA defections. Eight BRS legislators defected to Congress in function if not in law, campaigning under the Congress banner, and coordinating with its leadership. The Assembly Speaker did not disqualify them under the anti-defection law, leaving them formally as BRS members even as they operated as Congress on the ground. It is this legal grey zone that made reversals possible: the same MLA could

walk to the Congress for the panchayat elections, walk back to the BRS for the municipals, and never technically have left either party. The consequences are written plainly in the data. In the eight constituencies where MLAs crossed over, the BRS averaged just 18.6% against the Congress’s 61.8%. Where the BRS MLAs remained united, the party averaged 38.4%, nearly matching the Congress’s 37.7% (**Table 2**). A single MLA crossing the floor cost the BRS roughly 20 percentage points. Banswada is the starkest case, where the BRS was left with just a 2.2% share of panchayats.

Patancheru proved the effect works in both directions. Its BRS MLA crossed to the Congress in July 2024; Congress won the segment in December 2025. When the same MLA returned to the BRS in January 2026 before the municipal polls, BRS swept the urban wards in February 2026. That is, wherever MLAs held firm, the BRS showed that it remained a formidable local force. Harish Rao’s Siddipet returned 80% of panchayats to the BRS, reducing the Congress to 6.6%. K. T. Rama Rao’s Siricilla gave the BRS 47% of panchayats. The party finished second in 67 of 94 ACs despite having no government at any level and eight of its own legislators campaigning against it.

The BJP finished fourth or worse in 79 of the 94 rural/semi-urban constituencies, and won zero panchayats in 20 ACs. Any meaningful presence of the party was confined to just two northern Adilabad seats – Mudhole (49.7% panchayats) and Adilabad (35.3% panchayats). In south Telangana, the BJP is not just weakening; it does not exist.

A bipolar contest
The regional split sharpens the picture further. Northern Telangana, that is, the old districts of Adilabad, Nizamabad, Karimnagar, and Medak, account for 5,418 panchayats. The Congress won 47.5% panchayats here, the BRS 27.4%,

and the BJP 9.3%. Southern Telangana accounts for 7,284 panchayats, where the Congress won 58.3%, the BRS 27.9%, and the BJP collapsed to 2.7%. The pattern is clear: the BRS’s vote share is remarkably consistent across both regions, suggesting a baseline of organisational loyalty that does not depend on geography. The Congress is stronger in the south. And the BJP’s already thin State-wide presence is almost entirely a northern phenomenon, driven by sitting MLAs in Adilabad and pockets of Nizamabad and Karimnagar. This geographic context matters for reading the caste patterns that follow: tribal seats concentrate in the north, Dalit seats are more evenly spread, and the two geographies produce different competitive dynamics.

Looking at each party’s performance within reservation categories against its State-wide average, reveals a striking Congress-BRS mirror image. The Congress overperforms in tribal seats (Scheduled Tribes (ST) Women +5.8%, ST General +3.6%), likely reflecting post-2023 forest rights and tribal welfare policy. The BRS overperforms in Dalit seats (Scheduled Castes (SC) General +3.8%, SC Women +3.3%), retaining loyalty built during its decade in power. The BJP shows its only notable variance in Backward Classes women seats (+3.8%), reaching 9.4% against its overall 5.5% (**Table 3**). The SC base is the BRS’s most durable asset and the Congress’s most visible vulnerability.

The Congress’s 2023 wave has deepened rather than receded, reinforced by incumbency and absorbed MLA networks. Whether this is genuine organisational growth or just a ruling-party advantage will only become clear when it is no longer in power. The BRS survives as a collection of political fortresses, potent where its leaders held, hollowed out where they left. However, the BJP’s claim to a Telangana growth story is contradicted at every level of this data.

Panchayat verdict

The tables map panchayat results across constituencies, mandals and reservation categories to understand Telangana’s rural political balance

Table 1: Party performance in panchayat elections across Assembly Constituencies (ACs) and mandals

Party	Panchayats (%)	ACs led	Mandals led	2nd place in ACs	Data were sourced from Telangana State election commission and the authors' constructed dataset
Congress	53.7%	83	445	5	
BRS	27.7%	8	101	67	
BJP	5.5%	2	19	5	
Others	13%	1	25	17	

Total ACs: 94 | Total mandals: 590

Table 2: The effect of MLA defections on panchayat results	MLA status	BRS avg share	Congress avg share
	Crossed to Congress (8 ACs)	18.6%	61.8%
	Stayed with BRS (17 ACs)	38.4%	37.7%
	Difference	-19.7 pp	+24.1 pp

Table 3: Party performance by reservation category

Category	Seats	Congress %	Distortion*	BRS %	Distortion	BJP %	Distortion*
UR (General)	2,747	53.08%	-0.62%	28.54%	0.82%	6.3%	0.76%
UR (Women)	2,488	52.77%	-0.93%	28.50%	0.78%	6.07%	0.53%
BC (General)	1,215	52.59%	-1.11%	28.81%	1.09%	7.49%	1.95%
BC (Women)	962	51.66%	-2.04%	27.86%	0.14%	9.36%	3.81%
SC (General)	1,170	49.74%	-3.96%	31.54%	3.82%	4.79%	-0.76%
SC (Women)	918	50.76%	-2.94%	31.05%	3.33%	4.79%	-0.75%
ST (General)	1,741	57.27%	3.57%	24.35%	-3.37%	3.1%	-2.44%
ST (Women)	1,461	59.48%	5.78%	22.72%	-5%	3.08%	-2.46%

Distortion (in %) measures each party’s performance within reservation categories against its State-wide average

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Local poll: Voters wait to cast their votes during the second phase of the Telangana panchayat polls in Shivampet on Sunday. MOHD ARIF

FROM THE ARCHIVES



FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 26, 1976

New diversion line on S.C. railway

From our Vijayawada correspondent: A new diversion railway line between Bhigwan and Pophlaj stations on the Daund-Kurudwadi section of the South Central Railway, constructed at a cost of Rs. 6.91 crores, is expected to be thrown open to traffic in April.

The diversion to a length of 33 km has become necessary because of the Maharashtra Government’s decision to construct a dam on River Bhima, a tributary of the Krishna, at Ujjani, 150 km from Poona. The reservoir of the dam submerges the existing railway track for a length of 34 km.

The Government of Maharashtra has contributed Rs. 5.67 crores while the Railways are bearing the rest of the expenditure, as the diversion has been taken up at the instance of the Maharashtra government.

There are four major bridges on the new line – Bhima, Hingni, Bhopalpet and Pandara. The bridge on the Bhima is the longest with 23 spans of 60 feet each.

The work was started in 1971 and is now complete in all respects expect for the launching of girders on three bridges. The project has provided employment to the tune of 18 lakh mandays.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 26, 1926

Medicine in ancient India

Madura, March 25: Dr. Lakshmpathi delivered a lecture yesterday on “Indian medicine” in the Edward Hall, Madura, under the presidency of the Municipal Chairman, Mr. R.S. Naidu, Bar-at-Law. He said after the recent publication of the Artha Sastra, which was not merely a text book of political economy, but an encyclopaedia of contemporary scientific knowledge in all departments, the history of Indian medicine and the methods adopted by the ancient Hindus for living a healthy life, had become very clear. The work had given us strong contemporary evidence in proof of many valuable facts contained in ancient medical works. The scale of punishment laid down for infringement of public health rules was very severe. Society was thoroughly organised in the most democratic manner. The medical practitioners were held in great esteem. The physicians helped the King, in keeping up a high state of morality in the State.

CMYK A CH-CHE

ASSEMBLY POLLS

BJP will win 177 seats in Bengal polls: Suwendu

▼ Leader of the Opposition Suwendu Adhikari on Wednesday claimed that the Bharatiya Janata Party would win 177 of the 294 seats in the West Bengal Assembly polls. The BJP leader said if people were allowed to vote, “the BJP will win nothing short of 177 seats”. This is the first time that a

BJP leader in West Bengal has put up a figure on how many seats the BJP will win in the Assembly polls. There are 294 seats in the Assembly and the magic figure for securing a majority is 148 seats. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, while announcing candidates for the polls, had said her party would win at least 226 seats. In the 2021 Assembly polls, the Trinamool Congress had won 215 seats and the BJP was reduced to 77 seats.



BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari during an election campaign, in Kolkata. PTI

‘Grave breach’: CPI on EC letter with BJP seal

▼ Communist Party of India (CPI) Rajya Sabha member P. Sandosh Kumar has written to Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, flagging what he termed a “serious breach of institutional neutrality and procedural integrity” after an Election Commission communication was found with the seal of the BJP.

The Kerala Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) has reportedly acknowledged circulating the document, attributing the presence of the party’s seal to a “clerical mistake”, an explanation the MP described as untenable and deeply troubling. He argued that the incident goes beyond routine administrative lapses and strikes at the credibility and constitutional impartiality of the EC, especially at a time when public confidence in democratic processes requires utmost protection.



Some say there are many Muslims in Trinamool Congress. But that is anonymous leadership. What we want is leadership with a voice
ASADUDDIN OWAISI
AIMIM chief

R.G. Kar victim’s mother gets BJP ticket in Bengal

▼ The BJP on Wednesday fielded the mother of the doctor who was raped and murdered at Kolkata’s R.G. Kar Hospital and Medical College in August 2024. She will contest from Panihati in North 24 Parganas. The party also released candidates’ list for 19 other constituencies. The list includes many candidates from north Bengal.



If you criticise the government, you are put in jail, cut off from schemes. This is not the politics of democracy but fascism. People of Assam deserve better
GAURAV GOGOI
Congress leader



Twist in tale: The United People’s Party Liberation led by Pramod Boro walked out of its alliance with the BJP recently. FILE PHOTO

Lone rangers flex their muscle against alliances in Assam battle

Rahul Karmakar
GUWAHATI

The “non-aligned” political parties may become the dark horse in Assam’s electoral battle between two blocs – the National Democratic Alliance (NDA) and the Asom Sonmiloto Morcha (ASM). Mandate 2026 is largely expected to be a straight fight between the Bharatiya Janata Party-led NDA and the Congress-led ASM across Assam’s 126 constituencies. The BJP has three allies – the Asom Gana Parishad, the Bodoland People’s Front (BPF), and the Rabha Hasong Joutha Mancha. The Congress has five partners in the ASM – two of the Left Front, two sired the anti-Citizenship (Amendment) Act stir of 2019, and a hill-based tribal party. The two blocs are gung-ho about victory on April 9, the day of voting. However, the neutral parties have been gaining in confidence as the D-Day approaches.

The most confident among these parties are the All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF), which was part of the Congress-led Mahajot (Grand Alliance) during the 2021 election, and the United People’s Party Liberation (UPPL), which was the BJP’s ally five years ago. Both walked out of their respective alliance, the UPPL less than a fortnight ago.

Best strike rate

The AIUDF had the best strike rate in 2021, winning 16 of the 20 seats it contested. Mohammed Badruddin Ajmal, the party’s chief and candidate from central Assam’s Binnakandi seat, said the AIUDF had the firepower to at least match its 2021 performance. The AIUDF is contesting 27 seats, the bulk of them in Muslim-dominated areas. “Assam’s political landscape will undergo a major shift this time, as the minority people know both the BJP and the Congress have been exploiting them. The people also know today’s Congress is the A-team of the BJP,” he said. The UPPL, which won six of the 11 seats it contested in 2021, is equally upbeat about a good show. The party is contesting 18 seats, three beyond its core area covered by the Bodoland Territorial Region (BTR). “We are fighting this election independently because our grassroots supporters, our strength, wanted us to. We played a key role in restoring peace in the BTR, which is relapsing into violence,” UPPL president Pramod Boro said. Elected to the Rajya Sabha a few days ago, he is contesting the Tamulpur seat in the BTR. The UPPL ruled the Bodoland Territorial Council, which governs the BTR, in alliance with the BJP for five years until the BPF defeated it in the September 2025 council polls.

Other parties
Four other non-aligned political entities in the fray are the Trinamool Congress (contesting 23 seats), the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (21 seats), the Aam Aadmi Party (14 seats), and the National People’s Party (NPP) headed by Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K. Sangma, which is contesting three seats. These neutral parties do not face each other in many constituencies, raising hopes that they could cause an upset or two. The Trinamool Congress and the NPP drew a blank in 2021.

IN FOCUS

G. Anand
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Speculation is rife in the Congress over who will be the Chief Minister if the party-led United Democratic Front (UDF) wins the Assembly election in Kerala, despite the best efforts of the party leadership to tamp down such “schismatic” conjecturing. P.J. Kurien, veteran Congress leader and former Deputy Chairperson of the Rajya Sabha, on Wednesday pushed the organisational contestations over the Congress’s choice, at times muted and at times loud, into the public domain. At a UDF election convention in Thiruvalla, Mr. Kurien said the UDF would win on May 4, the poll results day. Pointing at senior party leader Ramesh Chennithala, who shared the dais with him, Mr. Kurien said, “I have no doubt that Mr. Chennithala will be the Chief Minister. He [Mr. Chennithala] might protest, saying that the party will decide,” he said. Varghese Mammen, a



Looking ahead: Congress leaders Sunny Joseph, V. D. Satheesan, Ramesh Chennithala and K.C. Venugopal at a party event in Thiruvananthapuram. A. JAYAMOCHAN

Kerala Congress leader contesting as the UDF candidate from Thiruvalla, sat next to Mr. Chennithala. Glancing at them, Mr. Kurien quipped: “Mr. Mammen will sit on the right of Mr. Chennithala on the Treasury bench in the Kerala Legislative Assembly after the polls.” Mr. Kurien’s statement sent the political rumour mill into overdrive. His

avermment went viral, with some channels claiming that the Kerala Pradesh Congress Committee’s senior leadership, including K. Sudhakaran, among others, backed Mr. Chennithala over Leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheesan and All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary K. C. Venugopal, to the high office. Mr. Chennithala later

made light of Mr. Kurien’s statement. He echoed the AICC’s line that the party’s national high command would take the final call in consultation with the members of the Congress Legislature Party. “The Congress and the UDF are marching in lockstep to end Left Democratic Front (LDF) rule. The aim of winning the elections gains primacy over everything

else,” he said. Senior Congress leader K.C. Joseph said senior leaders should “desist from broadcasting self-defeating conjectures” about the prospective Chief Minister. In a Facebook post, Mr. Joseph said the party was locked in a “live-or-die” electoral battle. “Tens of thousands of UDF workers are braving hostile circumstances, including the sweltering summer, to win the fight for the party and not to capture the Chief Minister’s post for any individual. Leaders should respect their sentiment and sacrifice,” he said. Mr. Joseph said he was not offering any counsel, but merely reminding leaders that they know how the Congress decides the party’s Chief Ministers. Mr. Satheesan sought to sidestep the debate. He told presspersons in Palakkad that the Opposition was fighting the polls as “Team UDF”. He noted, somewhat cryptically, that the Congress had “a galaxy of leaders” capable of executing any political task given to them by the party.

Singapore report ignites Zubeen death issue in Assam

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

In poll-bound Assam, Singapore coroner’s inquiry report has fuelled a debate over Assamese cultural icon Zubeen Garg’s mysterious death. In a judgment on Wednesday, the island country’s State Coroner, Adam Nakhoda, said Garg drowned accidentally and he found no reason to disagree with the Police Coast Guard’s findings about the nature of his death. Earlier, the Singapore General Hospital cited drowning as the cause of his death on September 19, 2025. Reacting to the coroner’s report, Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said the judgment and the chargesheet filed by the SIT of the Assam police were similar. However, he said in November 2025 that Garg had been murdered. State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi said the Singapore ruling challenged the Chief Minister’s murder theory. “The Indian government coordinated with its Singapore counterpart on this matter, and the Assam government sent a police team to Singapore to investigate. The Singapore verdict is a gift for those accused of killing him,” he said.

India’s ‘newest voters’ caught in SIR adjudication trap in West Bengal

Shiv Sahay Singh
DINHATA

Dinhata residents Manmohan Barman and Mohammad Mujjamel Khandakar are among India’s newest voters, with their citizenship recognised through an international agreement, but that has not stopped the Election Commission from putting them in the uncertain category of “electorate under adjudication”. Mr. Barman, 66, and Mr. Khandakar, 64, are both now residents of the Dinhata constituency in Cooch Behar district. Just over a decade ago, however, they lived in Dasiarchara, an Indian enclave located deep within Bangladeshi territory. In July 2015, they were among 989 people scattered across 11 Indian enclaves who chose to relocate to India after the Land Boundary Agreement (LBA) was signed, when the territory of those enclaves was absorbed into Bangladesh. At the same time, 14,854 residents of 51 Bangladeshi enclaves located within Indian territory also became Indian citizens as per the LBA. Mr. Barman and Mr. Khandakar have voted in several elections, but they have little hope that they will be able to vote in next month’s Assembly poll, gi-



Left out: Manmohan Barman and Mohammad Mujjamel Khandakar at a camp in Cooch Behar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ven the hurdle posed by the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. When the EC kicked off the SIR process in West Bengal in October 2025, residents of the settlement camp were sceptical about participating in the process. Their families have no legacy data to trace their ancestry to the 2002 voter list, since they had an effectively Stateless existence before 2015. Sure enough, their names cropped up in the “logical discrepancies” list after the first phase of the SIR. **Not in list** Now, nine members of the Khandakar family and four from the Barman family have found their voter status “under adjudication”. Their names were not included in the EC’s first list of those cleared through adjudication on March 23,

so their right to vote still hangs in the balance. “If we were to be denied voting, why were we brought here under the [bilateral Land Boundary] Agreement? By bringing in this SIR, we have been pushed towards uncertainty,” Mr. Khandakar said. The 58 families that have been living in the Dinhata enclave settlement camp since 2019, insist that they came to India through a bipartite agreement and thus should have not been subject to the SIR at all. Most of their youth have migrated for work and the elders fear that if their names are not cleared off the adjudication list, the youth may not return to vote. Mohammad Saraul, who runs a small grocery shop in the camp, said women like his wife, who were born in India and

have married erstwhile enclave dwellers now residing in the settlement camp, have been marked “under adjudication” in the lists. **‘Are we outsiders?’** Hamida Begum, 60, and Namita Barman, 39, both residents of the settlement camp, are angry. “Why did they put us under adjudication? Are we outsiders? The government brought us and now says we have no voting rights,” Ms. Barman said. Osman Gani, a resident of the Dinhata camp, claims that that there is a communal design in the way voters from minority communities have been kept “under adjudication”. “There are three enclave settlement camps for people who came from Bangladesh, located at Dinhata, Haldibari, and Mekhliganj. The camps at Haldibari and Mekhliganj have Hindu majority so most of the people have been cleared as voters during SIR. It is in Muslim majority areas that the names of electors remains stuck,” he said. Residents of Madhya Masaldanga, a Bangladeshi enclave that became part of India during the 2015 LBA-sanctioned swap of enclaves, say that since their right to vote is doubtful in the run-up to this election, no candidate has even reached out to them.

Names of 13 lakh Bengal voters under adjudication deleted

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

A decision has been made on 32 lakh voter records of the 60 lakh under adjudication in West Bengal till Wednesday, according to sources in the State’s Chief Electoral Office. Of the 32 lakh, names of at least 40% (about 13 lakh) have been deleted from the electoral rolls, the sources added. Around 28 lakh voters under adjudication are still waiting for a decision. The Election Commission had published the first supplementary list on March 23 midnight containing 10 lakh names. No details were formally shared by the EC officials on Wednesday about the number of deletions nearly 40 hours after publication of the first list. At least 60 lakh people across the State were put under adjudication with 700 judicial officers working to dispose of the pending cases. **Digital gap** While constituency and booth-wise data are available online, voters lament that the lists have not been displayed on paper in any government offices, leaving those without digital access scrambling for information. The names on the lists have to be verified individually after logging

Around 28 lakh voters under adjudication are still waiting for a decision in the State

into the Election Commission’s website. **Appeal to tribunals** The voters whose names have been deleted can make an appeal to the 19 tribunals set up across districts in the State. Their pleas will be reconsidered by these tribunals led by former judges. According to sources, the EC officials have sought permission from the Calcutta High Court to publish supplementary lists every day instead of publishing them every Friday. At least 522 voters were under adjudication in the Silampur I gram panchayat area in Sujapur constituency of Malda district where people alleged that 427 names have been deleted. “We have lived here for generations. My forefathers were born here. We are citizens of the place. What will we do now,” said a man in his 70s whose name has been struck off the list. Residents alleged large-scale deletions despite submitting documents during the special intensive revision (SIR) process.

CM
YK

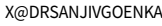
Saini replaces injured Harshit in the Knight Riders squad



Royal Challengers pacer Mangesh happy to make his father proud



Playoff entry not enough, LSG has to win first trophy: owner Goenka



Knight Riders retire talismanic all-rounder Russell's No. 12 jersey



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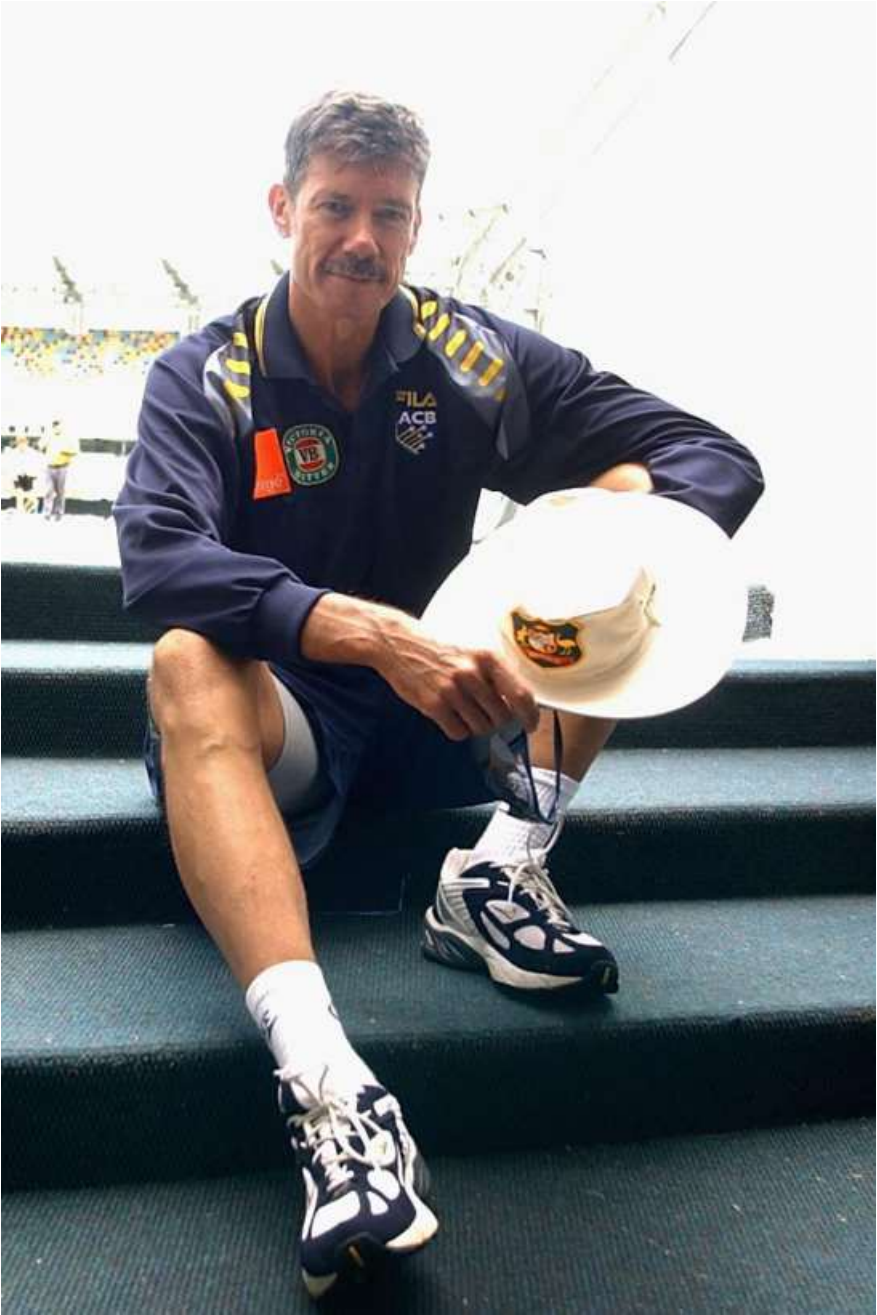
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Time for Australian cricket to do some soul-searching

Buchanan, the former coach, reflects on what it takes to build a successful unit; says he was fortunate to have worked with greats like Warne and McGrath; feels that the younger crop of Aussies has not able to survive at the highest level, particularly in the longest format



GETTY IMAGES

INTERVIEW

John Buchanan

S. Dipak Ragav

John Buchanan is one of the most successful coaches in international cricket. He presided over Australia's golden era, guiding the team to two World Cup titles in 2003 and 2007 – both achieved without losing a single match – and overseeing a side that won nearly three-fourths of the Tests it played during his tenure.

In this conversation with *The Hindu*, the 72-year-old reflects on what it takes to build a successful team, revisits some of the memorable battles against India, and shares his insights on the modern game. Excerpts

How do you assess the current state of Australian cricket?

They had a strong Ashes series before the T20 World Cup exit. They did win 3-1, but I thought it was a very disappointing series. The skill levels of both sides were not what I would term 'Test match standard.' And I say that not just because the matches lasted two or two-and-a-half days, but because, from both a batting and bowling perspective, I saw players unable to adapt and adjust their skills to the conditions.

Wickets always play a role, but the ones I saw shouldn't have dictated such short games. So, in a nutshell, I think it's time for Australian cricket to do some soul-searching. That includes taking accountability for both good and bad outcomes. Australia's record over the last three or four years across formats is still quite strong. Nonetheless, the results in T20 cricket are indicative of some underlying cracks in the system.

With players like Mitchell Starc, Steve Smith, and Josh Hazlewood nearing the end of their careers, how do you see the road ahead?

It ties back to what we just discussed. There will need to be turnover. In any team aiming for sustained success, you need a balance – experienced players alongside younger ones coming through.

Right now, particularly in Test cricket, Australia has a group dominated by older players, with very little infusion of young talent. The younger players who have come in occasionally, like Sam Konstas, haven't been able to survive at the highest level. A lot of this

comes down to the domestic system – the Sheffield Shield, the BBL, and the One-Day competitions. The issue is that the best players often do not participate in these tournaments. When they do get opportunities, they may opt out due to injury, rest, or time away from the game.

So, when your domestic system is no longer the best indicator of whether a player is ready for international cricket, then you've got a problem. That's something Australia needs to examine very carefully.

Do you see any promising youngsters coming through?

I don't follow the under-19 level closely anymore. But broadly speaking, I believe there is enough talent. The key question is whether that talent can be consistently executed at a higher level.

At the moment, the competitions these players are involved in are not sufficiently testing them. So while talent exists, the challenge is nurturing it into players who can perform consistently in international cricket.

What separates a good coach from a truly successful one at the highest level?

You can't make a silk purse out of a sow's ear – you need talented players. We were fortunate to have greats like Shane Warne and Glenn McGrath, and someone like Ricky Ponting, who was close to that level.

Just below them were players like Jason Gillespie, Matthew Hayden, and Justin Langer, who were also outstanding performers.

Then you need strong leadership – Steve Waugh and Ponting, supported by senior players like Adam Gilchrist.

That leadership shapes the team culture – how you prepare, how you approach the game, and how you respond to both wins and losses. Losing hurts, but then you are ready to make amends the next time around.

I remember after the 2007 World Cup, I was asked if I had ever coached the perfect match. I said no – we came close a few times, but never perfect. What we did have, though, was the perfect team: players who constantly looked to improve themselves.

How did you manage a team full of big personalities and still raise the bar further?

It wasn't always smooth sailing. Like any family, there were disagreements. Initially, it was about working with a small core group – Warne, McGrath,

the Waugh brothers, and Slater.

Others like Ponting and Gillespie were still establishing themselves, and Gilchrist was just starting. The first 18 months were about understanding how the group functioned before trying to make a significant impact.

Over time, I formed a close working relationship with Steve Waugh and Adam Gilchrist. Together, we focused on building the right culture, planning processes, and training methods. Even though we were winning, it took about 18 months for everything to really solidify.

Success played a key role – early wins helped players believe in the direction we were taking.

You were ahead of the curve with data and fitness. Was there resistance from players?

There's always resistance to change, especially when things are going well. But my view was that if we didn't evolve, other teams would catch up and surpass us. Take the example of our 'Target 400' approach. When I introduced it, players were enthusiastic, but they questioned how we would get there, given that our highest scores were around 340-350.

So we used data to show that we were only maximising about 50% of scoring opportunities. That meant there was untapped potential. From there, we focused on areas like running between the wickets. Technically, many players weren't efficient in that aspect. So that's where a physical change would come in. We needed to actually get them to understand how to get low and power out of their legs to give themselves momentum to get down the other end. These small improvements would help us extract more runs, either by converting singles into twos or scoring off previously unused deliveries.

What were the highlights of your coaching career?

Three moments stand out: Winning Queensland's first Sheffield Shield, coaching my first Test match in Brisbane, singing the national anthem, and finishing with the 2007 World Cup final. Those moments were deeply personal and meaningful.

Was there a player you were particularly fond of?

I'd say, Andrew Symonds. He wasn't necessarily the best or the most disciplined, but he brought something special to the team dynamic. He could bat, bowl both spin and medium pace, and

was an outstanding fielder. More importantly, we shared a strong relationship.

Which current Indian players have caught your eye?

Jasprit Bumrah stands out immediately. Alongside Starc, he's one of the leading fast bowlers in the world. He's composed, humble, and consistently delivers. I also really like Shubman Gill. I think he's a very special player.

What advice would you give to Shubman Gill as captain during this transition phase?

First and foremost, he has to perform as a player. Leadership becomes very difficult if you're not contributing with the bat. From there, he needs to back himself and his decisions. If you look at Steve Waugh and Ricky Ponting, they had different styles. Steve was someone who would generally quietly confide in people, but then make the decision. Ricky Ponting would always confide in a way that was very obvious, but still make the decision. Gill needs to find what works best for him.

Your favourite India-Australia contests?

The 2001 and 2004 series stand out. 2004 was a real achievement for us. But it was on the back of 2001 for me, because I hadn't been to India before then. I remember learning from E.A.S. Prasanna, S. Venkataraghavan, and B.S. Chandrasekhar. I got to meet Bishan Singh Bedi, just listening to them talk about spin bowling and how you do it and how you play it, and watching the Indian batters, how they play spin. So 2004 was a real outcome of what happened in 2001. The 2003 World Cup final against India was also an incredible performance.

Any regrets on enforcing the follow-on in that famous Test in Eden Gardens in 2001?

I regard it as one of my poor decisions as a coach. But it was not just about enforcing the follow-on. The game was set up nicely, and we had a big lead (274 runs). My job was not to get caught up in the emotion of what was going on the field. Except, I did. My job was to sit them down quickly as the players walked in and explain our options. I think they still would have all gone there (to enforce the follow-on), but I didn't take the time to get them to think that if we had batted, we would have batted India out of the game. Our objec-

tive was to go there to win the series. But we enforced the follow-on.

It was the way we'd been playing, and that was the obvious choice for us to make. We'd won the first Test (in Mumbai), albeit that was a little bit masked by Hayden and Gilchrist's performances. When I look back, they were playing sweeps, the balls were landing [in between fielders], and we had things going our way, which we probably ignored a little bit. And so the obvious decision was to enforce the follow-on, which we did, and the rest is history.

Can you elaborate on the strategy behind the 2004 series win in India?

Our strategy was to cut down scoring opportunities. Indian players are strong on the leg-side, so we used specific field placements – like multiple mid-wicket positions – to create pressure. We focused on bowling at the stumps and back-of-a-length deliveries, forcing batters to take risks. We also mixed in short balls to disrupt the rhythm.

The idea was to restrict boundaries, force errors, and take the crowd out of the game. In India, once the crowd gets behind the team, it can be overwhelming for the opposition. And Warne's role was somewhat less; he was to play a supporting role, not necessarily a lead one, which didn't fit his ego.

But by that stage, he was very much governed by all the players around him, and so they didn't let him get away and let him go and do his own thing. And the other thing was that Adam Gilchrist really stuck to the plan (Ponting was injured for the first three Tests), which made a big difference as well.

What's your take on India's success, especially in white-ball cricket, and the overall state of Indian cricket today?

I may not follow it as closely as I once did, but my overall view is that Indian cricket is heading exactly where you would expect – a powerhouse of world cricket. There is an enormous pool of talent, and the competition to get into the national team is incredibly high. As a result, the players who do make it are generally very well prepared for international cricket. You can see that in their recent performances, including the T20 World Cup win. Their ODI side has also been performing very credibly. The depth of talent pushing through – whether into India-A or the senior team – will continue to ensure India remains a dominant force.

West Asia conflict: how finding oil changed the Persian Gulf’s ecology

The Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz bring oil and war to mind, but until recently the region looked very different; to see how, it is only necessary to look at its shallow waters and precarious coasts, where many fragile ecosystems live amid heat, salinity, ships, and geopolitical tensions

Ipsita Herlekar

Military ships and oil tankers dominate how we imagine the Persian Gulf today. Yet beyond this familiar imagery of geopolitics and petroleum lies a mosaic of vulnerable ecosystems.

It wasn’t always this way. Just six decades ago, these waters were busy not with warships but fishing boats, and the glittering megacities that now line the coast were then little more than fishing villages.

The Gulf coastline is remarkably young. Formed 3,000 to 6,000 years ago as the sea flooded the Arabian basin through the Strait of Hormuz, it is today a shallow, semi-enclosed sea spanning about 226,000 sq. km, with an average depth of just 30 m.

Its shallowness and limited water exchange with the open waters of the Arabian sea drive its extreme conditions. The summer temperatures regularly exceed 35 °C while the high rate of evaporation keeps the water salty to the tune of 44-70 parts per thousand – almost twice as salty as open sea water.

Yet life persists.

Life on the edge

At the boundary of land and sea lies the intertidal zone – shaped by cycles of exposure and submergence to heat and hypersalinity.

These are dynamic systems where organic matter breaks down and is recycled, helping microorganisms survive in the adjacent waters. Beyond them, lagoons host specialised microbes and commercially important species like shrimp. Mangroves are fish nurseries, migratory bird refuges, and carbon sinks.

The mudflats also sustain shrimp as well as coastal food webs while the offshore seagrass meadows are among the Gulf’s most productive ecosystems, proving to be places where fish and pearl oysters spawn.

These meadows are also important feeding grounds for sea turtles. Five of the world’s seven sea turtle species occur here, including the critically endangered Hawksbill sea turtle, and nest along parts of the coast despite the wars.

The Gulf’s waters also support the world’s second-largest population of dugongs outside Australia, with an estimated 5,000 to 6,000 individuals. Dugongs are marine mammals that depend almost entirely on seagrass to survive.

Scattered across these waters are coral reefs covering an area the size of Goa. They support several fish and invertebrate communities. Importantly, they can survive extreme conditions, making them a natural laboratory for scientists to understand how coral ecosystems might respond to climate change.

Together, the Gulf is a finely balanced ecological network adapted to extremes.

At its peak, in the 18th to the early 20th centuries, the Gulf’s oyster beds supported a thriving economy that supplied nearly 80% of the world’s Basra pearls, named after a port in Iraq. This system collapsed when Japanese cultured pearls entered the market in the 1920s.

Then people found oil. By the 1970s, oil had made West Asia one of the world’s fastest-growing regions. Today, the Gulf region alone produces nearly a third of the world’s oil, with around 800 offshore



Birds take flight around vessels in Persian Gulf waters near Hormuz Island, Iran, in 2011. NINARA (CC BY-SA)

platforms and more than 25,000 tankers moving in and out every year. Nearly a fifth of the world’s oil passes through these waters.

This wealth has driven rapid urbanisation. The number of people has tripled in four decades, with more than 85% of people and economic activity concentrated within 100 km of the coast.

Coastlines remade

Large-scale land reclamation, dredging, and engineering have transformed the shorelines. In Dubai alone, more than 60% of the natural coastline has been changed.

Projects such as Palm Jumeirah have altered currents and sediment flows, eroding sand in some areas and causing sand to accumulate in others, leaving beaches to be maintained constantly.

Nearly two-thirds of the salt flats have disappeared, mangroves have shrunk, and natural beaches have been replaced with seawalls that eliminate nesting grounds for birds and turtles. Seagrass beds and mudflats have been buried under land reclamation projects, removing important nursery habitats for marine life.

The consequences have also extended offshore. Coral reefs have been buried or smothered by sediments while dredging and construction have disrupted natural flows.

These physical changes have been compounded by industrial pressures such as desalination and pollution.

The Gulf hosts about half of the world’s desalination plants, with over 200 facilities producing around 11 million cubic metres of freshwater every day.

They produce hot, saline brine, often laced with chemicals and heavy metals, that is discharged into the sea, where it accumulates in the semi-enclosed basin, further raising temperatures and salinity.

The Gulf coastline is remarkably young. Formed 3,000 to 6,000 years ago as the sea flooded the Arabian basin through the Strait of Hormuz, it is today a shallow, semi-enclosed sea spanning about 226,000 sq. km, with an average depth of just 30 m

Intake systems also remove plankton and larvae, disrupting the base of the food web.

War and water

Algal blooms fed by sewage deplete oxygen and trigger mass fish deaths, such as those recorded off Kuwait’s shores in 1999 and 2011. Chronic nutrient loading also disrupts coral physiology, increases bleaching, and suppresses the growth of seagrass.

Industrial pollutants further accumulate in marine life. The pearl oyster (*Pinctada radiata*), once central to Gulf economies, has borne the brunt of pollution and sedimentation, which have left behind degraded oyster beds.

Leaks, spills, and tanker traffic continue to damage ecosystems. The 1991 Gulf War spill devastated coastlines, mangroves, bird populations, and fisheries while oil fires spread pollutants far afield. The UN Compensation Commission awarded Kuwait \$52.4 billion for a clean-up; decades later, the effort is still underway.

These threats persist even today. The oil infrastructure continues to be a target of drones and missiles, and rising temperatures trigger repeated coral bleaching, pushing already stressed ecosystems to the brink.

The consequences extend far beyond the sea. Across West Asia, the Arabian

oryx, populations of the Asiatic cheetah, and the Arabian leopard have fallen sharply due to hunting and other conflicts. The Arabian oryx vanished from the wild by 1972. Then, the Phoenix Zoo in the U.S., Fauna & Flora International in the U.K., and the World Wide Fund for Nature reintroduced it in Oman in 1982, with populations later established across Saudi Arabia, Israel, the UAE, and Jordan. Meanwhile, the Asiatic cheetah survives in Iran in critically low numbers.

Repeated wars have also derailed conservation efforts. The Iranian Revolution in 1979 followed by the Iran-Iraq War in 1980 brought wildlife protection to a near halt, leaving protected areas to decay and wildlife populations to crash.

A narrowing window

Today, the Gulf is among the worst affected marine regions on the planet. But signs of awareness do exist. The UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Qatar have imposed limits on shrimp trawling. The UAE and Saudi Arabia are also leading mangrove restoration efforts and, together with Kuwait, have established marine protected areas to conserve what remains of these ecosystems.

As marine biologist and New York University (Abu Dhabi) professor John Burt noted in his work on Gulf ecosystems, the region’s highly centralised governance – for all its deficiencies – could also facilitate rapid environmental action. What is required is for ecological concerns to be prioritised at the highest levels.

Time is also limited. Ecosystems such as coastal swamps, salt pans, oyster habitats, and the nesting sites of endangered sea turtles are already approaching points of no return.

(Ipsita Herlekar is an independent science writer. ipsitaherlekar@gmail.com)



A truck carries the transportable antimatter trap during a road test at CERN near Geneva, Switzerland on Tuesday. AP

Antiprotons take a ride in novel test by CERN scientists

Associated Press

Scientists in Geneva took some antiprotons out for a spin – a very delicate one – in a truck, in a never-tried-before test drive that has been deemed a success.

If this so-called antimatter came into contact with actual matter, even for a fraction of an instant, it would have been annihilated in a quick flash of energy. So experts at the European Organization for Nuclear Research, known as CERN, over the course of four hours on Tuesday, brought about 100 antiprotons on the road. The antiprotons were suspended in a vacuum inside a specially designed box and held in place by supercooled magnets. After easing them from the lab and onto the truck, the scientists transported the antimatter on a half-hour drive to test how the infinitesimal particles could be transported by road without seeping out. The antiprotons were then taken back to the lab in the final stage that concluded with applause and a bottle of champagne.

For every type of particle that exists in the universe, there is a corresponding antiparticle, with an opposite charge. Manipulating antimatter, like antiprotons, can be tricky business

CERN spokesperson Sophie Tesauri called the experiment successful. It was not immediately clear how many antiprotons had survived the entire journey, but roughly 91 of 100 were still there after the truck’s trip.

Manipulating antimatter, like antiprotons, can be tricky business. As scientists understand the universe today, for every type of particle that exists, there is a corresponding antiparticle, exactly matching the particle but with an opposite charge. If those opposites come into contact, they “annihilate” each other, setting off lots of energy, depending on the masses involved. Any bumps in the road on the test journey that are not compensated for by the specially-designed box could spoil the whole exercise. “The motivation behind these experiments is to compare matter and antimatter with extremely high accuracy and watch for differences which we might have not seen yet,” said Stefan Ulmer, the leader and spokesperson for Tuesday’s experiment.

The experiment was a first step toward making good on hopes, one day, to deliver CERN antiprotons to researchers at Heinrich Heine University in Düsseldorf, Germany, which is about eight hours away in normal driving conditions. The antiprotons were encased in a 1,000-kg box called a transportable antiproton trap. It was compact enough to fit through ordinary laboratory doors and fit on a truck. It used superconducting magnets cooled to -269°C that allowed the antiprotons to remain suspended in a vacuum – not touching the inner walls, which are made of matter. The mass in the test – slightly less than that of about 100 hydrogen atoms – is so little, experts say, that the worst possible outcome was the loss of the antiprotons. Even if they did touch matter, any release of energy would be unnoticeable. Only an oscilloscope, which picks up electrical signals, would have been able to detect it. The trap, says Ms. Tesauri, “is supposed to contain these antiprotons no matter what: if the truck stops, if it starts again, if it has to slam on the brakes – all that”.

Work remains: the trap can contain the antiprotons on its own for only about four hours, and the drive to Düsseldorf is twice that.

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Survival struggle: when and how animals go extinct

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

When the last individual of a species worldwide has died, it is said to become extinct. What is the single-word term for when the last individual of a species has died in a particular region even as the species persists in other areas?

QUESTION 2

_____ is a name for evolution within a single lineage where a population changes so significantly over time that it is reclassified as a new species. As a result of this, the ‘old species’ is said to end as the ‘new species’ begins. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 3

X extinction is when a species still exists but its population is so small that it no longer plays a significant

role in its ecosystem. Y extinction is like X extinction taken to an extreme, i.e. when the species is so rare that its presence in the ecosystem can be ignored without consequence. Name X and Y.

QUESTION 4

Individuals of a species whose numbers have fallen below the _____ are sometimes called the ‘living dead’. This is because the population no longer has the genetic diversity for the species to adapt well to new threats and/or it is losing too much habitat. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 5

A species is said to have an _____ if an event in the past is bound to lead to the species being wiped out in future. Fill in the blanks with a description coined so because the species is ‘owed’ to extinction.



Visual: Name this fish. It’s a good example of a Lazarus taxon, which denotes a species thought to be extinct but which is then rediscovered. AMELIA GUO

Answers to March 19 quiz:

- Minimum amount of fissile material for a chain reaction – **Ans: Critical mass**
 - Method used to eliminate mosquitoes’ breeding grounds – **Ans: Drain the swamp**
 - When too much NaCl in soil dehydrates plants – **Ans: Salting the earth**
 - Name for assets that threaten the health of institutions – **Ans: Toxins**
 - Temperature point when an environment is ready to combust – **Ans: Flashpoint**
- Visual: **Runaway**

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For feedback and suggestions

for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Prisoners benefiting from support scheme for poor inmates

458 Minister of State for Home Affairs Bandi Sanjay Kumar said the scheme aims to provide financial assistance to prisoners who are unable to pay fines or secure bail due to financial constraints. PTI

Political prisoners released by the Cuban government

20 Cuba has freed at least 20 political prisoners. The unusual show of clemency was made after President Miguel Diaz-Canel confirmed that his government was in talks with the U.S. amid rising tensions between the two countries. AFP

The estimated value of India's healthcare sector by 2030

700 in \$ billion. The country's healthcare ecosystem was valued at around \$300 billion in FY25 and projected to reach \$700 billion by 2030, but health financing remains underpenetrated. PTI

Number of Lokpal complaints registered in 2025-26

389 Anti-corruption ombudsman Lokpal registered 389 complaints in 2025-26 (till February this year), Union Minister Jitendra Singh said on Wednesday. The Minister said the Lokpal disposed of 336 complaints. PTI

Number of migrants who died on the Eastern Route in 2025

922 The number of migrants who died on the "Eastern Route" from the Horn of Africa to the Arabian Peninsula doubled to a record high of 922 last year, the UN migration agency said. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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What is at stake at the WTO's MC14?

What is the context in which MC14 is taking place? What has weakened the WTO's dispute settlement system? What are the key issues before MC14? Why is the e-commerce moratorium contentious? What role should India play at MC14?

EXPLAINER

Prabhash Ranjan

The story so far: The World Trade Organization's (WTO) 14th Ministerial Conference (MC14) will take place from March 26 to 29 at Yaoundé, Cameroon. The conference is the WTO's highest decision-making body and generally meets once every two years. It is empowered to make all decisions on WTO law and to chart a path for the organisation's future work.

What is the context in which MC14 is taking place?

MC14 is taking place amid rising geopolitical rivalry between the U.S. and China, ongoing global conflicts, and the mounting securitisation of international trade relations. Furthermore, trade multilateralism appears to be in retreat, while unilateralism is on the rise. The U.S. has, over the last year, launched a massive assault on trade multilateralism by weaponising tariffs. Arbitrary tariff impositions by the U.S. grossly violate the cardinal rules that underpin the WTO, namely the most favoured nation (MFN) rule, which epitomises non-discrimination, and the obligation not to impose tariffs beyond bound rates. The U.S. has also begun signing new, one-sided trade agreements with countries through tariff coercion.

Why is trade multilateralism reeling under a crisis?

There is a growing belief in Washington that the WTO, which the U.S. was instrumental in creating in 1995, has not served American interests well. The meteoric rise of China in the last two decades has significantly narrowed the gap between Washington and Beijing. Moreover, China's accession to the WTO, which the U.S. facilitated, has not had the desired impact of disciplining Beijing's state-led industrial policies.

Consequently, the U.S. now wants to



GETTY IMAGES

eliminate all legal constraints that apply to it, such as WTO law, to take on the Chinese threat head-on. For this reason, the U.S. paralysed the WTO's dispute settlement system by relentlessly blocking the appointment of members to the Appellate Body – the organisation's highest judicial arm.

Another key reason for the crisis is the WTO's inability to draft new trade rules due to consensus-based decision-making. Over the past three decades, the WTO has created only two new agreements: the Trade Facilitation Agreement and the Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies. The sluggishness in forming new trade rules has pushed countries to seek new venues for trade law-making, such as free trade agreements (FTAs).

What are the key issues in MC14?

A fundamental issue at MC14 is whether plurilateral agreements, such as the Investment Facilitation for Development, endorsed by over 120 countries, and the Agreement on Electronic Commerce, should be incorporated into the WTO rulebook.

Although the WTO is a multilateral organisation, it allows plurilateral trade agreements – agreements between fewer

than all WTO members. These are typically included in Annex 4 of the WTO treaty. Plurilateral agreements bind only the signatories. However, for inclusion in Annex 4, such agreements must be approved by consensus among all WTO members.

Given the difficulty of achieving consensus, many countries believe that plurilateral agreements are the way forward to reinvigorate the WTO's legislative function. On the other hand, a few countries, such as India, argue that inaugurating the plurilateral rule-making door would open a Pandora's box and lead to the fragmentation of the system. It will be riveting to see whether countries can break this logjam at MC14.

Another key issue is the WTO's e-commerce moratorium. First agreed in 1998 and renewed every two years, this agreement among WTO member countries not to impose tariffs on electronic transmissions has benefited digital trade. This moratorium is set to expire on March 31. While the developed world wants it to be made permanent, the choice is not so easy for developing countries like India. Given the rise in digital trade, continuing the moratorium could lead to significant revenue losses for

developing countries.

The 166 WTO member countries meeting in Cameroon are also expected to deliberate on issues of special and differential treatment (SDT) for developing and least developed countries (LDCs). SDT, part of the 'WTO reforms', recognises that, since not all WTO members are on an equal footing, special rights shall be conferred on developing countries and LDCs. The U.S. is keen to weaken the SDT principle by prohibiting larger economies, such as China, India, Brazil, and Indonesia, from enjoying special rights.

On dispute settlement reforms, it is critical to unequivocally demand the restoration of the Appellate Body to put the WTO's dispute settlement system back on track.

The U.S. is also expected to use MC14 to challenge foundational WTO principles, such as the MFN rule. Developing countries that benefit from these principles should strongly oppose such efforts.

What should be India's role?

India, which has always maintained its support for trade multilateralism, needs to walk the talk. It should regain its role as the normative leader for the third world by using the MC14 to articulate the importance of multilateralism and to forge alliances with other developing countries.

To do so, New Delhi should not shy away from re-visiting its deeply entrenched positions, such as opposing plurilateral agreements. India, along with other countries, should also consider other innovative solutions, such as electing Appellate Body members through voting. If MC14 fails to strengthen the WTO and promote trade multilateralism, it will represent a victory for America's blatant unilateralism and its effort to establish a new global trade order rooted in coercion. This will be detrimental to the developing world.

(Prabhash Ranjan is a Professor and Vice Dean (Research), Jindal Global Law School. Views are personal)

THE GIST

MC14 takes place amid rising U.S.-China rivalry, global conflicts, and the retreat of trade multilateralism, with unilateralism and tariff coercion on the rise.

Key issues include plurilateral agreements, the e-commerce moratorium, SDT, and restoring the Appellate Body, with developing countries seeking to protect the WTO system.

Why is Chennai's microplastic problem bigger than it looks?

What are the ecological risks of microplastics in beach sediments?

T.V. Padma

The story so far:

Microplastics, especially nylon fibres, seem to be present rather sparsely in Chennai's beach sediments but could still wreak long-term ecological damage, new research has cautioned. A study by researchers at V.O. Chidambaram College in Thoothukudi examined the abundance, sources, and ecological risks of microplastics from beach sediment samples from 15 sites along the Chennai coast. The findings show fibres dominating, with most particles smaller than 1000 µm.

Why does low abundance not mean low risk?

"This study is important because it shows that microplastics are already present in Chennai's beach sediments, even if we don't always see them," Sekhar Selvam, senior assistant professor at the

Department of Geology, V.O. Chidambaram College, Thoothukudi, said. "We found that most of the microplastics are nylon fibres, which are more harmful than many other plastics."

In other words, even though Chennai's beaches have fewer microplastics than many global ones, the risk to marine life remains significant.

An additional insight from the study is the disconnect between abundance-based assessments and risk-based evaluations, Shaji Erath, professor of geology at the University of Kerala, Thiruvananthapuram, said. Traditional monitoring often focuses on microplastic counts alone.

However, the study has shown that polymer type, shape, and aging characteristics are equally, if not more, important in determining ecological risk, he added.

What are the ecological concerns? Ecological concerns in the study are

chiefly centred on marine life and coastal ecosystems, Dr. Selvam said. Small organisms living in beach sand, such as worms, crabs, and shellfish, easily ingest the small plastic fibres, which can go on to block or injure their digestive tracts. Toxic compounds in plastics can also enter and poison their bodies.

According to Dr. Erath, besides feeding by marine microorganisms, plankton, and marine animals, hazardous polymers such as nylon pose higher ecological risks due to their persistence, chemical additives, and capacity to adsorb pollutants.

Fibre-shaped microplastics in particular can alter habitats by modifying the structure of sediments, affecting the benthic – or bottom layer – of seas and the microbial communities there, he explained. There could also be prolonged environmental exposure and long-distance transport of microplastics, highlighting the transboundary nature of microplastic pollution.

How do human activities contribute?

Most microplastics found by the Chennai study team were clearly linked to human activities, according to Dr. Selvam. These include fishing, where damaged nets and ropes shed plastic fragments that break up into microplastics; synthetic clothes, which release minuscule fibres when they are washed; tourism and beach use; and urban sewage and stormwater drains that carry plastics into the sea.

After reaching the coast, they reenter human bodies via seafood contaminated by microplastics, among other pathways. Seafood in particular can ferry both harmful chemical substances and disease-causing bacteria and other microorganisms into the body, causing tissues to become inflamed and affecting the hormonal and immune systems over longer periods.

Is it too late to act?

Right now, microplastic pollution levels are not so extreme in Chennai and better waste management, responsible fishing practices, and public awareness can still prevent a much bigger problem in the future, according to Dr. Selvam.

In the final analysis, the research has reinforced the need for timely policy-driven interventions, including better solid waste management, recycling of fishing gear, promotion of biodegradable alternatives, and public awareness, Dr. Erath said.

(T.V. Padma is a science journalist based in New Delhi)

THE GIST

Microplastics, especially nylon fibres, are present in Chennai's beach sediments in relatively low abundance, but low overall microplastic abundance does not necessarily imply low ecological risk.

Even small particles can cause long-term ecological damage by affecting marine life, moving up the food chain, and eventually impacting human health through contaminated seafood.

